



THE NATIONAL GUIDE

Moving to New Zealand

*A new role, a different pace of life and
somewhere new to call home.*

Ethicare Resourcing

14 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date – so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

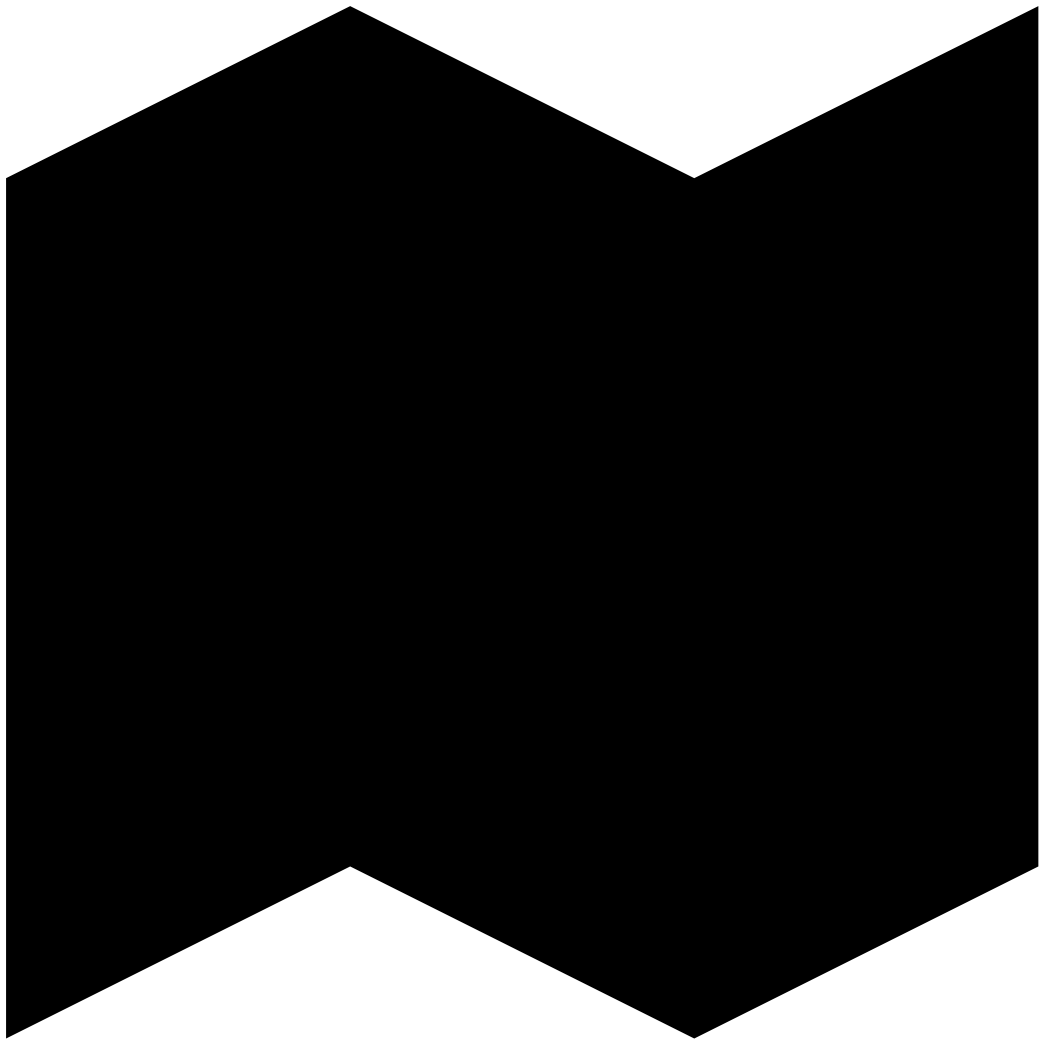
Aotearoa in short

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 1 of 15

A country of extraordinary landscapes — from the towering Southern Alps to tranquil fiords, geothermal marvels and pristine coastlines.



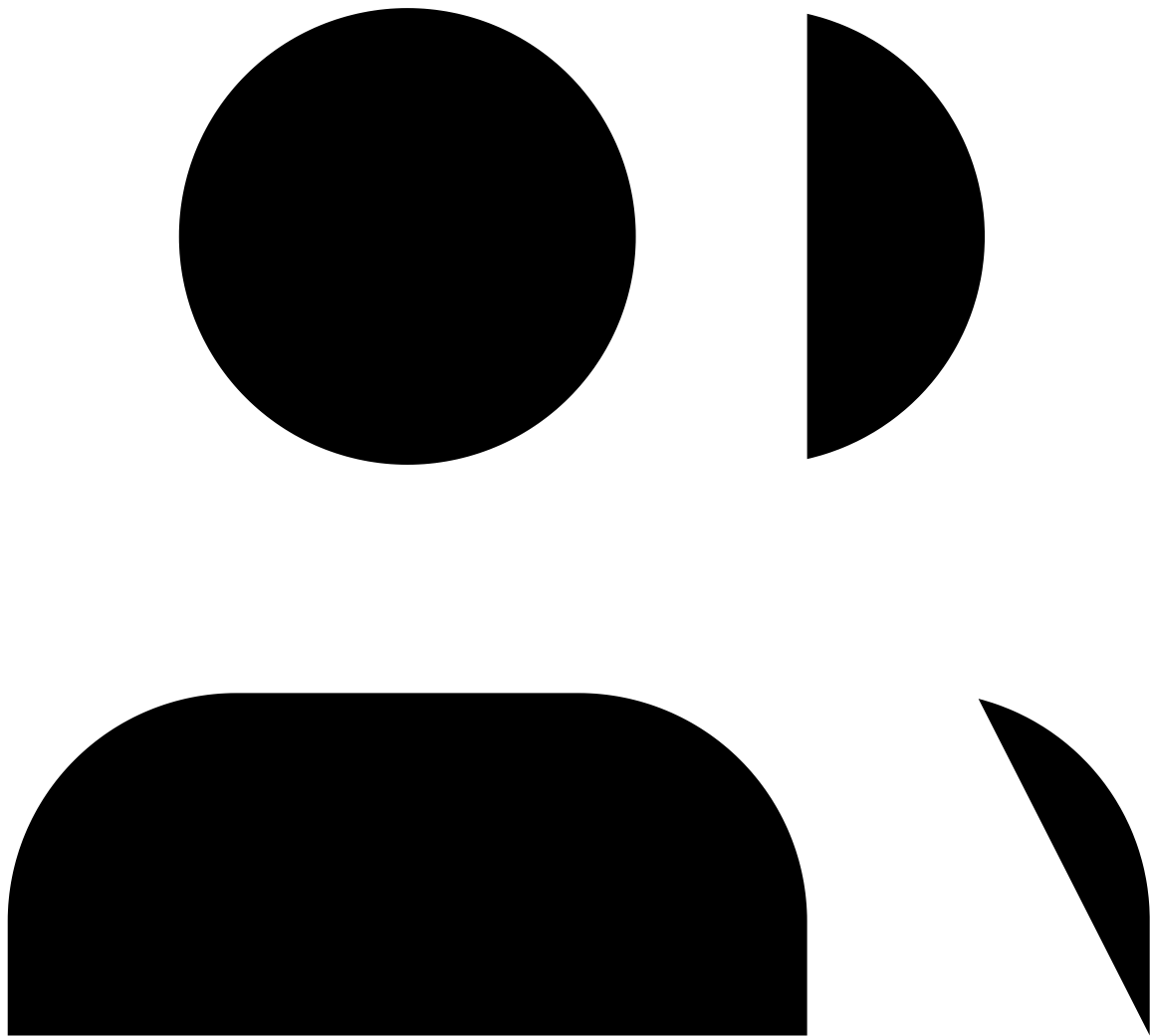
Kettle on. A longer read — about 4 min



2
Main islands – North & South



15Kkm
Of stunning coastline

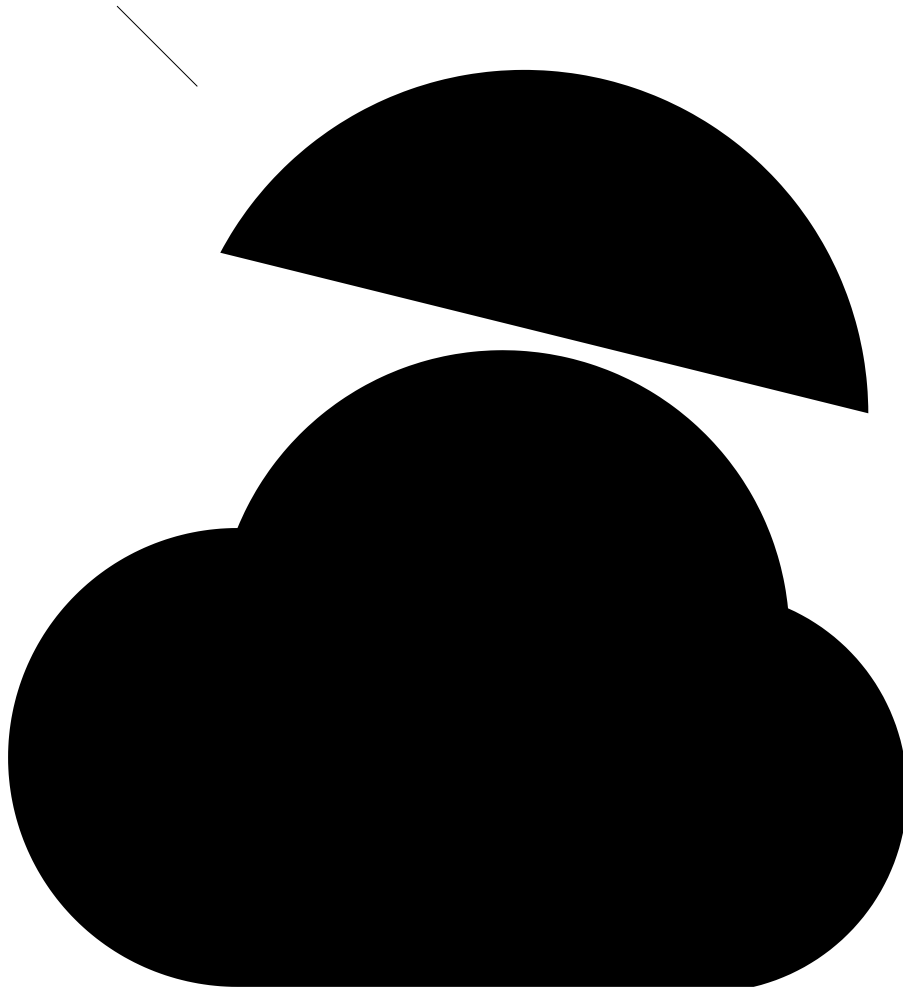


5.2M

Friendly residents (Kiwis)

New Zealand sits in the south-western Pacific, around 1,900 km south-east of Australia. Its geography has sculpted a playground for outdoor enthusiasts and a haven for those who appreciate nature's splendour.

Whether you're drawn to snow-capped mountains or pristine coastlines, every corner of the country is a visual masterpiece. This diversity is mirrored in a climate that shifts from the subtropical north to the alpine south.



Four climate zones at a glance

Subtropical – Northland & Auckland: warm, humid summers, mild winters

Temperate – most of the North Island: warm dry summers, cooler wet winters

Continental – Canterbury & Otago: hot dry summers, cold frosty winters

Alpine – the Southern Alps: cold year-round with heavy winter snowfall

A temperate, four-season year

The average temperature decreases as you travel south. January and February are the warmest months; July is the coldest.

Summer

Dec – Feb

20–25°

Avg daytime

Autumn

Mar – May

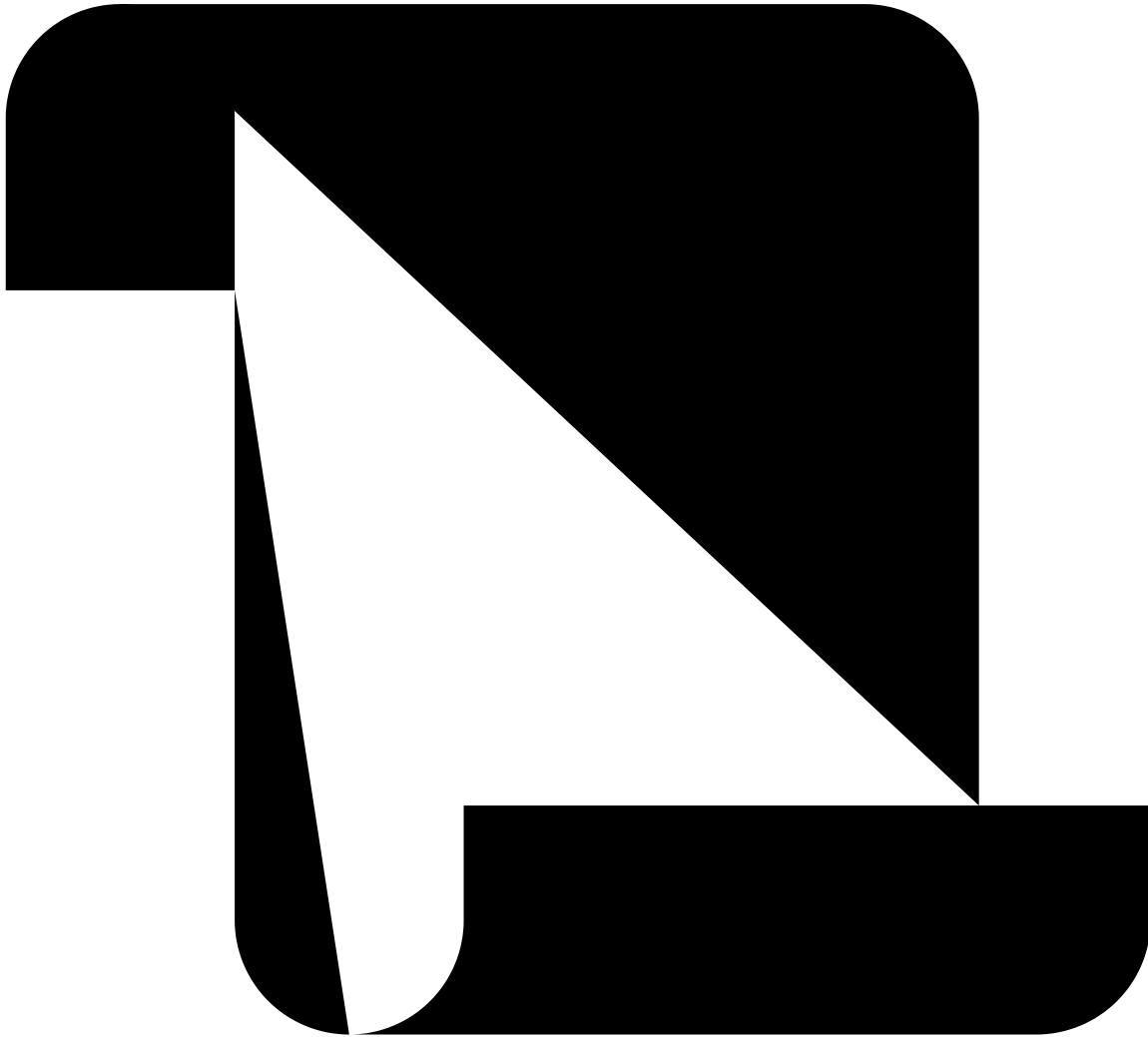
17–21°
Avg daytime
Winter
Jun – Aug
12–16°
Avg daytime
Spring
Sep – Nov
16–19°
Avg daytime
A culture worth understanding

New Zealanders — Kiwis — are known for being warm, direct and easy-going, with a deep love of the outdoors and a genuine respect for work-life balance. You'll feel welcomed quickly, and family life is given real room to breathe.

Aotearoa weaves together Māori heritage and influences from across Europe, the Pacific and Asia. Te reo Māori, tikanga (customs) and manaakitanga (care for others) are woven through everyday life — not a museum piece, but a living part of how the country works.

“

Māori make up over 14% of the population — their language and culture shape every facet of New Zealand life.



Te Tiriti o Waitangi & the Tiaki Promise

Te Tiriti o Waitangi (1840) – the founding agreement between the Crown and Māori, widely understood today as the document that guides the partnership between government and Māori. You'll hear it referenced often.

The Tiaki Promise – a shared commitment to care for New Zealand's land, sea and culture. "Tiaki" means to care for; the idea is simple – treat the place, and its people, with respect.

Three official languages – English, te reo Māori and New Zealand Sign Language.

Stable & progressive – a parliamentary democracy with a strong culture of human rights, environmental care and dependable public services.

Ten small things that make New Zealand, New Zealand

A few of the quirks and claims to fame you'll pick up not long after you arrive.

01

02

03

The kiwi — a flightless, nocturnal bird found nowhere else, and the affectionate name locals give themselves.

The haka — the Māori ceremonial dance the All Blacks perform before every match, known the world over.

Geothermal country — sitting on the Pacific Ring of Fire, Rotorua bubbles with geysers, hot springs and mud pools.

04

Adventure capital — Queenstown is the birthplace of the bungee, with skydiving, skiing and jet-boating on tap.

05

Votes for women — in 1893 New Zealand became the first self-governing country to grant women the vote.

06

No snakes — there are no native snakes anywhere in the country, on land or in its waters.

07

Middle-earth — the Lord of the Rings and Hobbit trilogies were filmed across its landscapes.

08

Dark skies — the Aoraki Mackenzie Dark Sky Reserve offers some of the Southern Hemisphere's best stargazing.

09

A very long name — Taumatawhakatangihangakoauauotamateaturipukakapikimaungahoronukupokaiwhenuakitanatahu, a Hawke's Bay hill, is among the world's longest place names.

10

Few land mammals — apart from bats, New Zealand has no native land mammals, and no native land snails or frogs either.

Understanding healthcare in New Zealand

A clear, honest picture of how New Zealand healthcare works for your own family's care, public, private and ACC.

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 3 of 15 All 15 chapters →

PAGE AT A GLANCE



Kettle on. A longer read — about 10 min

1. [How the system is structured](#)
2. [ACC, the no-fault scheme](#)
3. [Everyday healthcare & GPs](#)
4. [What care costs](#)
5. [Dental & private insurance](#)
6. [Official links](#)

THE BIG PICTURE

A publicly funded system, built on care for everyone

New Zealand's health system is largely public, funded through taxation, and free or low-cost for residents and many people on longer work visas. The principle behind it is deeply held: good healthcare should not depend on your bank balance.

For you, this matters in two ways. As a new resident, it shapes how you and your family will access care. And as a healthcare professional, it shapes the system you'll practise within: its values, its structure and its priorities. A little orientation now makes both feel far less unfamiliar.

One reassurance up front: the fundamentals will feel recognisable to anyone from a comparable system. **The differences are mostly in the details**, a no-fault accident scheme, the way primary care works, and a strong, explicit commitment to equity.

HOW IT'S STRUCTURED

The parts that make up the system

A handful of pieces fit together to deliver care. Understanding who does what makes the whole thing much easier to navigate, for your family and in your work.

The public system

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora

The national organisation that runs publicly funded health services, hospitals, specialist and community care, across the country. Recent reforms brought services under one national body to make care more consistent wherever you live.

Primary care

GPs & community services

General practitioners are the front door to most healthcare. You enrol with a local practice, and your GP handles everyday care and referrals onward to hospital or specialist services when needed.

Accident cover

ACC, the no-fault scheme

A uniquely New Zealand feature: a national scheme that covers treatment for injuries from accidents, for everyone, regardless of fault, including visitors. More on this below.

The private system

Private hospitals & insurance

A private sector runs alongside the public one. Many people hold private health insurance for faster access to elective procedures and more choice, while relying on the public system for emergencies and complex care.

— THE ONE THAT SURPRISES PEOPLE

ACC: accident cover for everyone

ACC is a no-fault scheme covering treatment and rehabilitation for accidental injury, for residents and visitors alike. In return you generally cannot sue for personal injury — one of the things newcomers find most unfamiliar.

No-fault

If you're injured in an accident, you're covered regardless of who was to blame, at work, on the road, on the ski field or at home.

For everyone

Cover extends to everyone in New Zealand, including international visitors and people on any visa, not only residents.

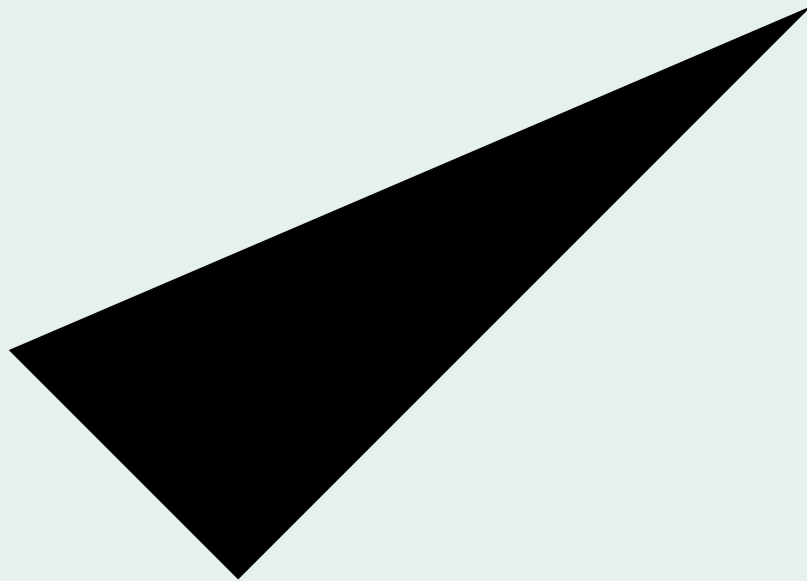
Treatment & recovery

It helps with treatment costs, and can contribute to rehabilitation and lost income while you recover from a covered injury.

— EVERYDAY HEALTHCARE

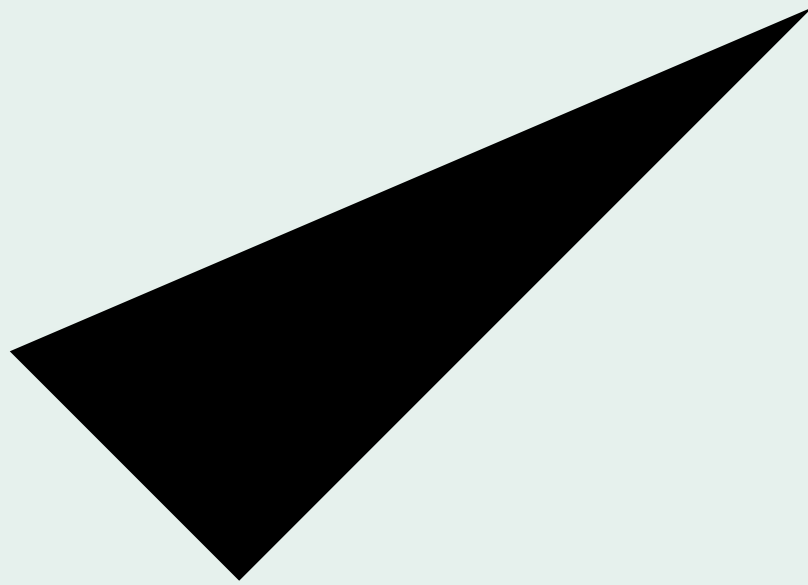
Getting care, day to day

For most things, your journey starts with your GP. Here's how the everyday side works, the practical bits you'll want sorted in your first weeks.



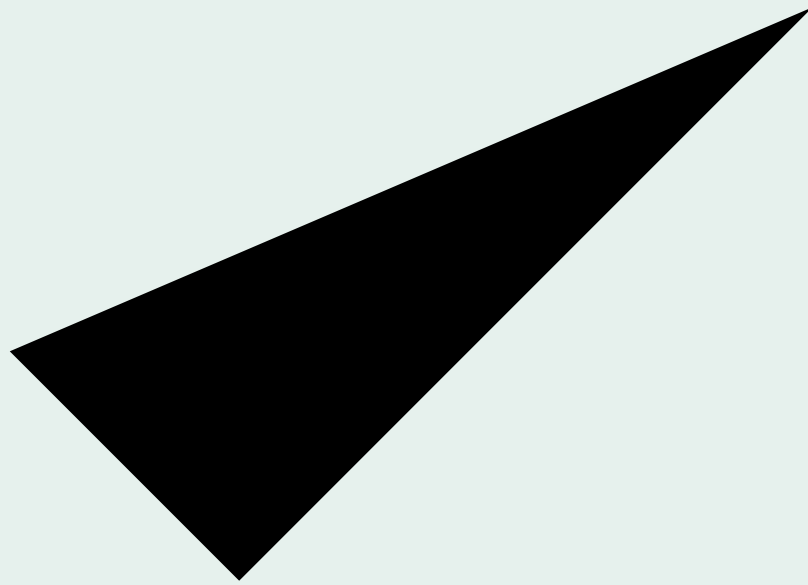
Enrol with a GP practice

One of the first things to do on arrival. Enrolling makes everyday visits cheaper and gives you a regular doctor who knows your family's history.



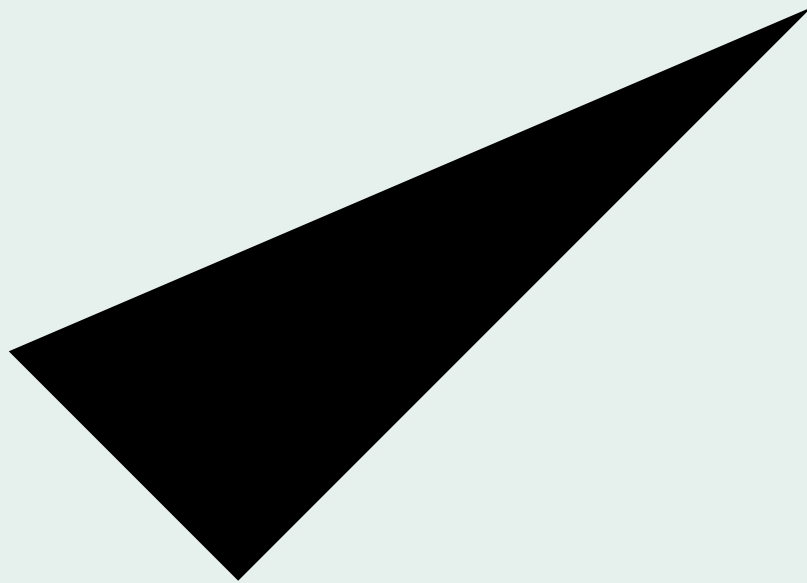
GP visits carry a part-charge

Primary care is subsidised rather than free for adults, so you pay a part-charge per visit. Care for children is heavily subsidised, and often free.



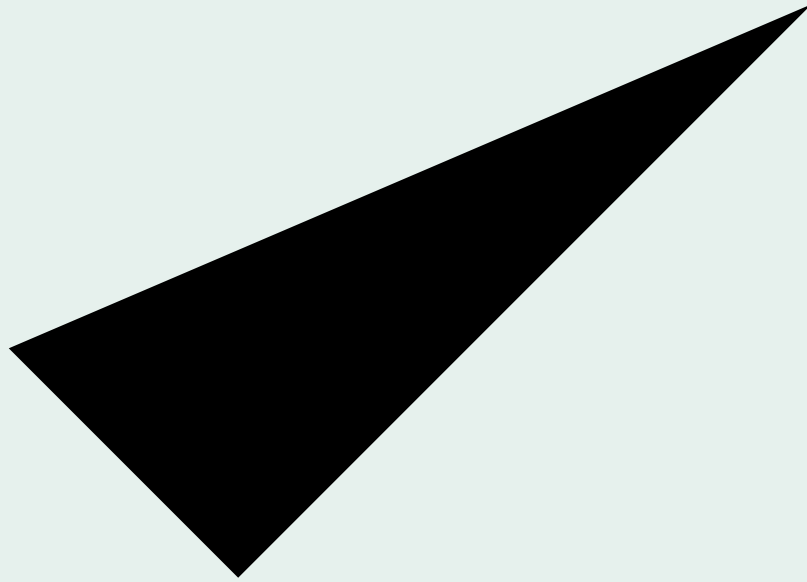
Prescriptions are subsidised

Pharmac, a government agency, decides which medicines are publicly funded, keeping the cost of most prescriptions low at the pharmacy counter.



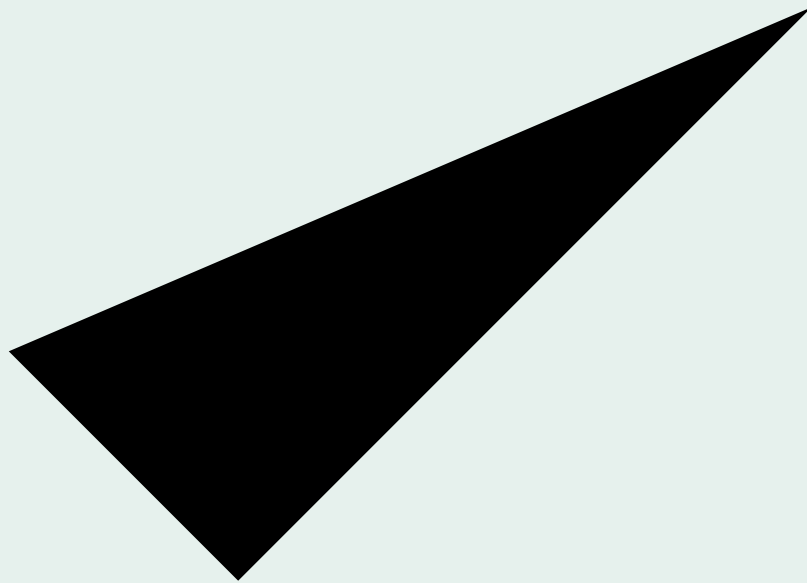
Hospital & emergency care

Public hospital and emergency treatment is free for eligible residents. In a genuine emergency, call **111** for an ambulance.



Healthline, any time

A free 24/7 phone line staffed by nurses for health advice when you're unsure whether to see a doctor, useful in the early days before you have a regular GP.



After-hours & urgent care

Urgent care clinics handle the things that can't wait for a GP appointment but aren't emergencies, handy to know where your nearest one is.

TOLD STRAIGHT

What healthcare costs

The honest summary: the big, frightening costs are covered, while everyday primary care carries modest charges. Here's the shape of it for an eligible resident.

Public hospital & emergency

Free for eligible residents and citizens, including surgery, specialist and emergency care.

Accident-related treatment

Largely covered by ACC for everyone, including visitors, with some part-charges depending on the care.

GP visits

A subsidised part-charge per visit for adults; care for children is heavily subsidised and frequently free.

Prescriptions

Low cost for funded medicines, thanks to Pharmac subsidies at the pharmacy.

Dental & optical (adults)

Mostly private and paid for out of pocket, though dental care is free for children and teenagers.

Private healthcare

Optional: private insurance buys faster access to elective procedures and more choice, on top of public cover.

Exact charges vary by practice, region and your eligibility, and the rules can change. Always confirm current detail with the practice or the official sources below. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not a health authority.

TWO QUESTIONS EVERYONE ASKS

Dental care, and whether you need private insurance

Two of the most common questions, because both work differently here. The short version: dental is mostly private for adults, and private health insurance is a choice rather than a must.

Dental · children

Free for under-18s

Basic dental care is free for children and teenagers up to their 18th birthday, through school dental services and enrolled community providers. It's one of the quieter things families appreciate here.

Dental · adults

Mostly private & out of pocket

Adult dental isn't generally publicly funded, so you pay privately, check-ups, fillings and the rest. Costs vary between practices, so it's worth comparing and booking a first check-up once you've settled.

Dental · the exceptions

Accidents, emergencies & hardship

Dental treatment for an accidental injury is covered by ACC, public hospitals handle some acute and emergency dental, and limited grants exist for people on low incomes. Outside those, plan for adult dental as a private cost.

Private insurance

Optional, not a necessity

You don't need private health insurance to be cared for: the public system covers emergency, hospital and essential care for eligible residents, and ACC covers accidents for everyone. Many people still take out cover for faster elective surgery, more choice of specialist, and sometimes dental and optical extras, and some employers offer it as a benefit. It sits on top of the public system, it doesn't replace it.

Eligibility, funding and grants change over time and depend on your visa and circumstances, confirm the current detail with a practice or the official sources below. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not a health authority.

“Optional” depends on what you are used to

Everything above is written as though not holding cover were the obvious default. For a clinician arriving from the UK or Ireland, it is. For a great many of the people we place, it is not, and this is the part worth saying plainly.

If you are coming from **South Africa**, a medical aid scheme is not a luxury upgrade at home. It is close to how a professional household gets care at all, the premium is a fixed and substantial line in the monthly budget, and stopping it would be unthinkable. The same is broadly true arriving from the **United States**, and from parts of the **Gulf** and **Asia** where employer-provided cover is the mechanism rather than a benefit.

So we watch people arrive here and immediately buy a comprehensive family policy, because that is what a responsible parent does where they come from. Often they did not need to, and nobody told them.

The reason it is different here is not that New Zealand insurance is better. It is that the two things insurance protects you against elsewhere are already covered: **acute and emergency hospital care** is provided by the public system for eligible residents, and **anything caused by an accident** is covered by ACC for everyone in the country, including visitors and people on any visa. The catastrophic scenarios. The crash, the sudden admission, the injury on a ski field, are the ones you are already covered for.

And one difference from Australia that matters if you are weighing both countries. Australia gives higher earners a tax reason to hold private hospital cover; New Zealand gives none. [How the Australian system works](#) sets out that mechanism, and [Australia versus New Zealand](#) compares the two properly.

The practical consequence is this: advice that is sound in Sydney is wrong in Wellington. Here the decision is purely about what you want, not about what you will otherwise be charged.

None of which makes cover pointless. Waiting times for *elective* procedures in the public system are real and can be long, and that is precisely what a policy buys you, a knee done in weeks rather than months, your choice of specialist, a private room. It buys time and choice. It does not buy safety, because you already have that.

Our honest suggestion: arrive, register with a GP, and give it three months before you decide. You will be in a far better position to judge what you actually want to insure once you have used the system rather than imagined it. If your employer offers cover as a benefit, take it. That is different, and it is free.

Sophie's insight

The clinicians we place often tell me the system here lets them practise the way they always wanted to, with time to actually know their patients and a team that pulls together. The bits that feel foreign at first, like ACC or enrolling with a GP, become second nature within weeks. My advice is to get your family enrolled with a local practice early, and to come curious about the emphasis on equity and Māori health. It's one of the things that makes practising here feel meaningful.

One honest caveat, though: "a team that pulls together" is true of many of the places our clinicians land, not a promise about every one. Team culture varies as much between workplaces here as it does anywhere — so it's worth asking what a particular team and department are really like when you interview, and talking to people already doing the job.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

OFFICIAL SOURCES

Check it at the source

The system evolves, and the official sites carry the current detail. These are the ones worth bookmarking, for your family's care and your own professional context.

The public system

How care is run & delivered

**Health New Zealand | Te
Whatu Ora** (<https://www.tewhatauora.govt.nz>)

Health information & services (<https://info.health.nz>)

Healthify · health topics A–Z (<https://healthify.nz>)

Accidents & medicines

ACC & subsidised medicines

ACC · accident cover (<https://www.acc.co.nz>)

Pharmac, funded medicines (<https://pharmac.govt.nz>)

**Healthpoint · find a
service** (<https://www.healthpoint.co.nz>)

Everyday & urgent

When you need help

Healthline · free nurse advice

(<https://www.healthline.govt.nz>)

Emergencies

· dial 111

(<https://www.tewhatauora.govt.nz/health-services/emergency-care>)

Find urgent &

after-hours care

(<https://www.healthpoint.co.nz/urgent-care/>)

Eligibility for publicly funded care depends on your residency and visa status. Confirm yours with Te Whatu Ora. Rules and charges change over time, so always check the current position at the source.

KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

PreviousChoosing where to liveAll chaptersNextTe ao Māori at work

Te ao Māori at work

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 4 of 15

Te reo Māori is woven through everyday New Zealand life, and in healthcare it arrives with something more: a Treaty relationship that shapes how care is designed, measured and delivered. None of this asks you to arrive expert. It does ask you to arrive willing.



Kettle on. A longer read — about 6 min

Te Tiriti o Waitangi, in practice

Signed in 1840 between Māori and the Crown, Te Tiriti is the founding agreement of the country. The history sits in [About New Zealand](#) — what matters on your first shift is what the Treaty relationship asks of you as a clinician, because your professional body will assess you against it.

Partnership

Working *with* Māori patients, whānau and communities rather than delivering to them. Decisions made together, and plans the whānau has genuinely agreed to.

In practice The person answering your questions may not be the person who decides. Ask who should be part of the conversation before you start, not after the plan is written.

Participation

Māori involvement at every level — in their own care, and in how services are designed and run. Kaupapa Māori providers deliver care by Māori, for Māori, and you will refer to them and work alongside them.

In practice If a service is not reaching a group, that is treated as a service problem to solve — not a patient problem to record as non-attendance.

Protection

Actively protecting Māori health and wellbeing, and closing outcome gaps that are well documented and long-standing.

In practice Equity is not equality. Two people with the same diagnosis may need different amounts of your time, and giving it to them is the standard rather than favouritism.

Te Whare Tapa Whā

A Māori model of health you are likely to meet in your first week: wellbeing as a house standing on four walls, on the whenua beneath it. If one wall is weak the house is unstable – which is a more useful way to think about the person in front of you than a problem list is.

PhysicalTaha tinana

The body – pain, function, mobility, strength, nutrition. What most of us were trained to assess first.

Mind & emotionsTaha hinengaro

Thoughts, feelings and mood. Rarely separable from a clinical outcome, and increasingly assessed alongside it.

Family & socialTaha whānau

Family and belonging. Who someone is caring for, and who is caring for them, is clinical information.

Spirit & meaningTaha wairua

Purpose, identity and meaning – what the person is actually trying to get back to.

Land & rootsWhenua

Connection to place and to whakapapa: the ground the four walls stand on. A person's home, land and community are part of their health rather than the backdrop to it.

Used well this is not an extra form to complete. It is a prompt that a goal recorded as “increase shoulder range to 140°” may matter far less to the person than being able to lift a grandchild, or to stand and speak at a family gathering.

Cultural safety, plainly

Clinical competence is performing the technique correctly. Cultural safety is the patient's judgement of whether your care was safe for them – which is why you cannot self-certify it, and why it is assessed as an ongoing competency rather than completed as an induction module.

In day-to-day terms it is unremarkable good practice. Nobody expects fluency on arrival. People do notice effort.

Learn to pronounce names, place names and the local iwi correctly – and ask if you are unsure.

Ask who should be part of the conversation before you begin, rather than after the plan is written.

Offer whānau a seat. Assume they are staying unless told otherwise.

Explain what you are about to do to someone's body before you do it.

Notice when someone has gone quiet, and do not read silence as agreement.

Do not assume the patient is the decision-maker, or that they are not.

Record goals in the person's own words, not translated into clinical language.

Accept correction without defending yourself. It is offered as help.

On a marae

You may be welcomed onto a marae for a service opening, a team day or a pōwhiri. You will be guided throughout and nothing is expected of you beyond following your host's lead.

The short version

- Wait to be called on. Do not walk ahead of the group.
- Remove your shoes before entering the wharenui.
- No food or drink inside the wharenui, and do not sit on tables or pillows.
- Dress tidily and modestly; keep phones away and silent.
- A hongi – the pressing of noses and foreheads – is a greeting, not a kiss.
- Follow the lead offered to you.
- Koha is a contribution, usually collected by the group rather than by individuals.
- Speeches take the time they take. That is the point of them.
- What all of this means inside your own discipline – the assessments, the goal-setting and the situations that catch overseas clinicians out – sits on your profession's page. [Find your profession](#)

Kōwhaiwhai: the painted patterns you will see on a marae

For the wider picture – the funders, the system priorities and what feels different across every profession – see [practising in Aotearoa New Zealand](#).

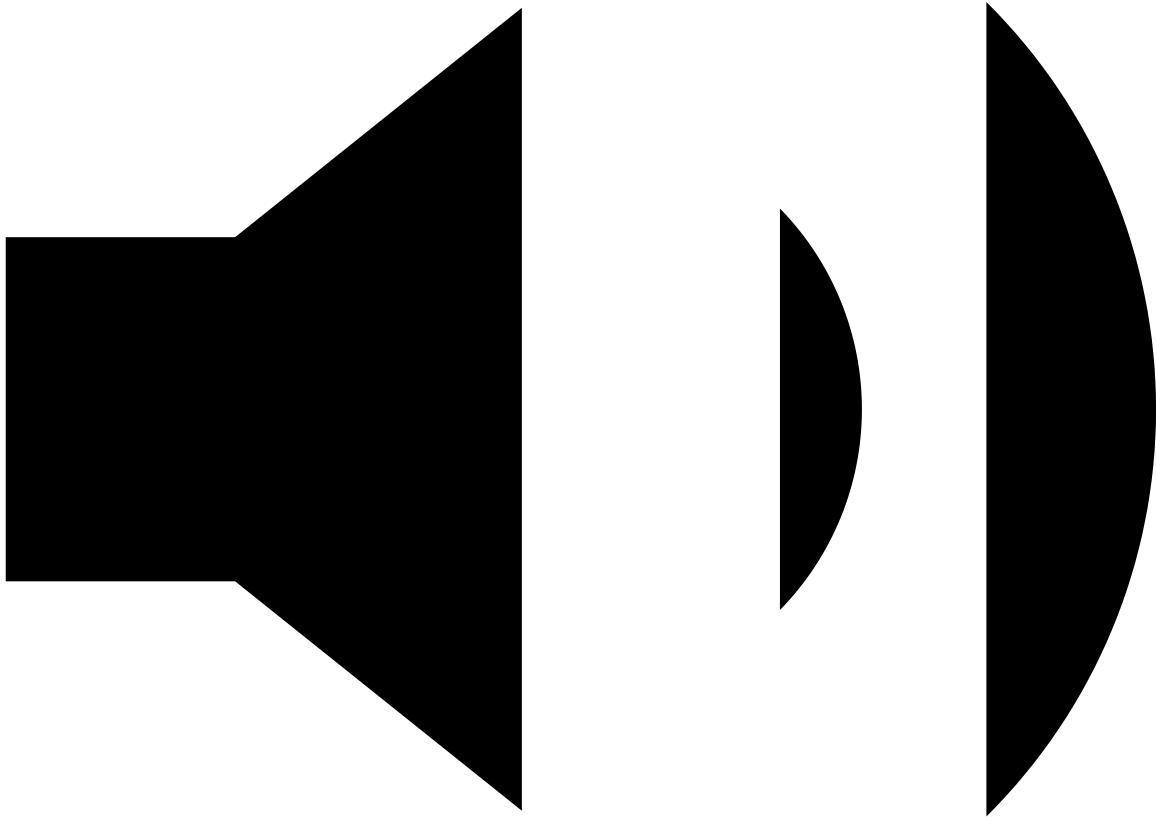
Words you'll hear

Examples to reo Māori

- Hello / thanks / cheers
- ng
- mai Welcome
- ou later
- koe? How are you?
- I'm fine / it's okay
- ase
- Many thanks
- Family / community
- children
- Elders
- and wellbeing (holistic)
- Hospitality, kindness, caring for others
- nga Guardianship of the land and environment
- ve, compassion, empathy
- Stay strong / be strong
- all done / good
- odbye (to someone leaving)
- Genealogy, ancestry, connection
- Aotearoa New Zealand – "land of the long white cloud"

What you'll hear

s No worries / great
Cheers / thanks / awesome
Interested / up for it
Lots
Corner shop
Swimwear
Flip-flops
Our turn to pay
Shared rental living
Tired
Remote area
Hard case A funny character



A quick guide to pronunciation

Vowels are pure and consistent: a = "ah", e = "eh", i = "ee", o = "aw", u = "oo" — every time.

"Wh" sounds like "f" — so whānau is "fah-now".

"R" is lightly rolled, closer to a soft "d" than an English r.

Macrons (ā ē ī ō ū) simply lengthen the vowel — Māori is "Maa-ori".

Place names reward a go: Taupō is "Toe-paw", Whangārei is "Fong-ah-ray". Locals value the effort far more than perfection.

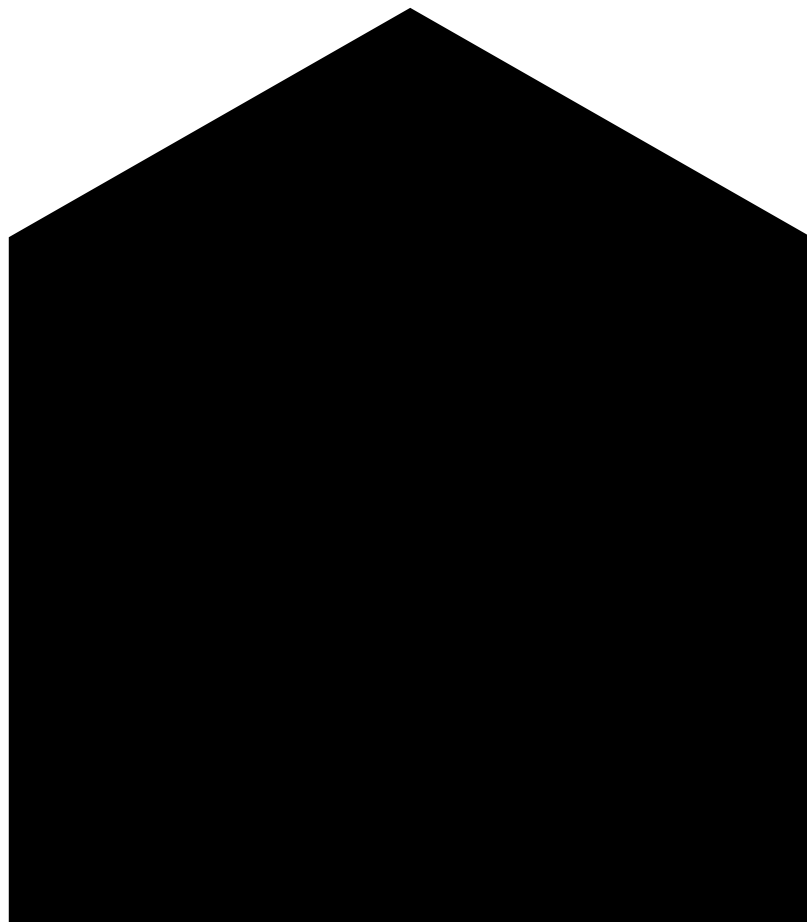
Money, tax & banking

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 5 of 15

A handful of early tasks will get your finances running smoothly. Most can be started before you arrive and completed in your first few weeks.

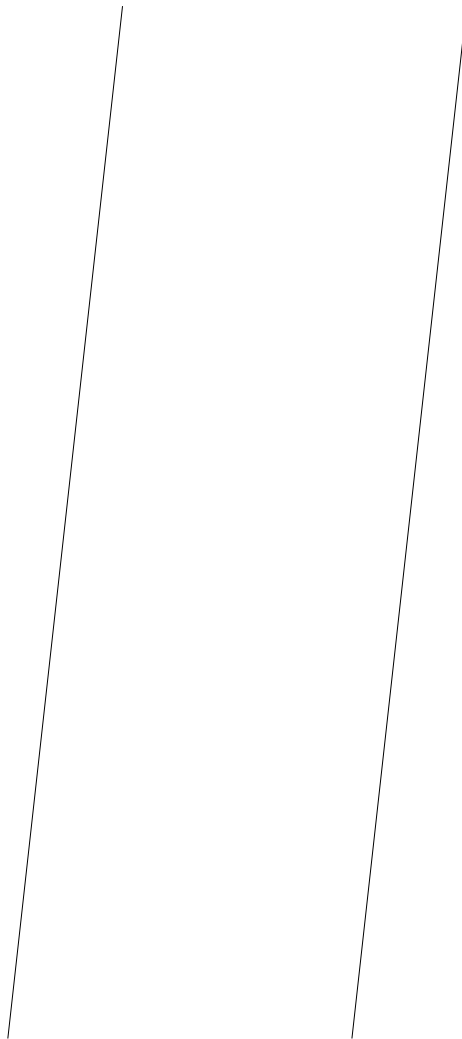


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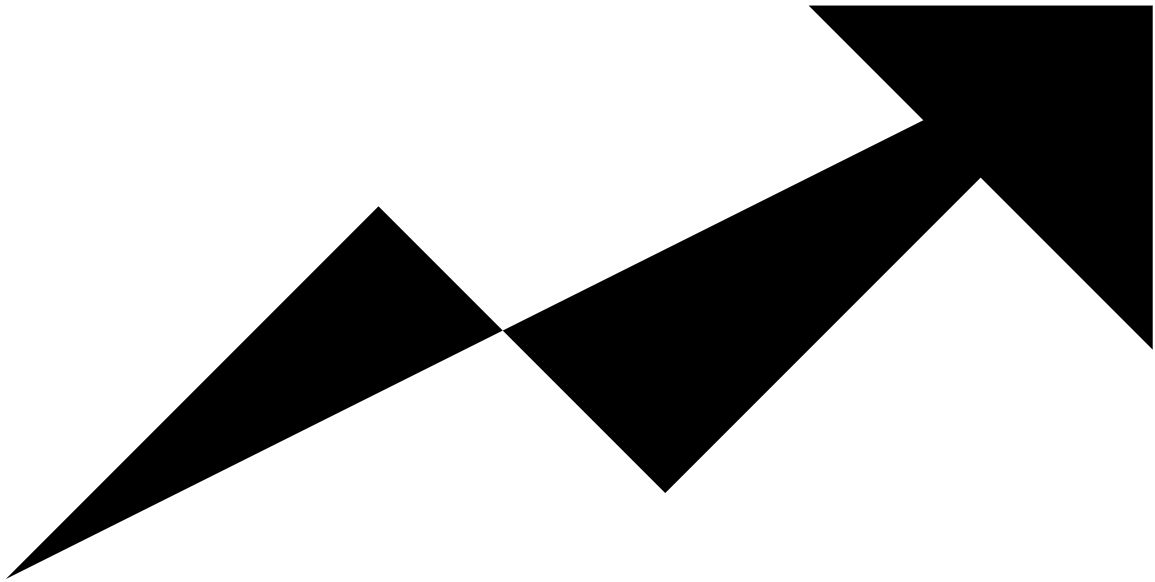
Bank account

Receive your salary and pay bills locally – start before arrival where possible



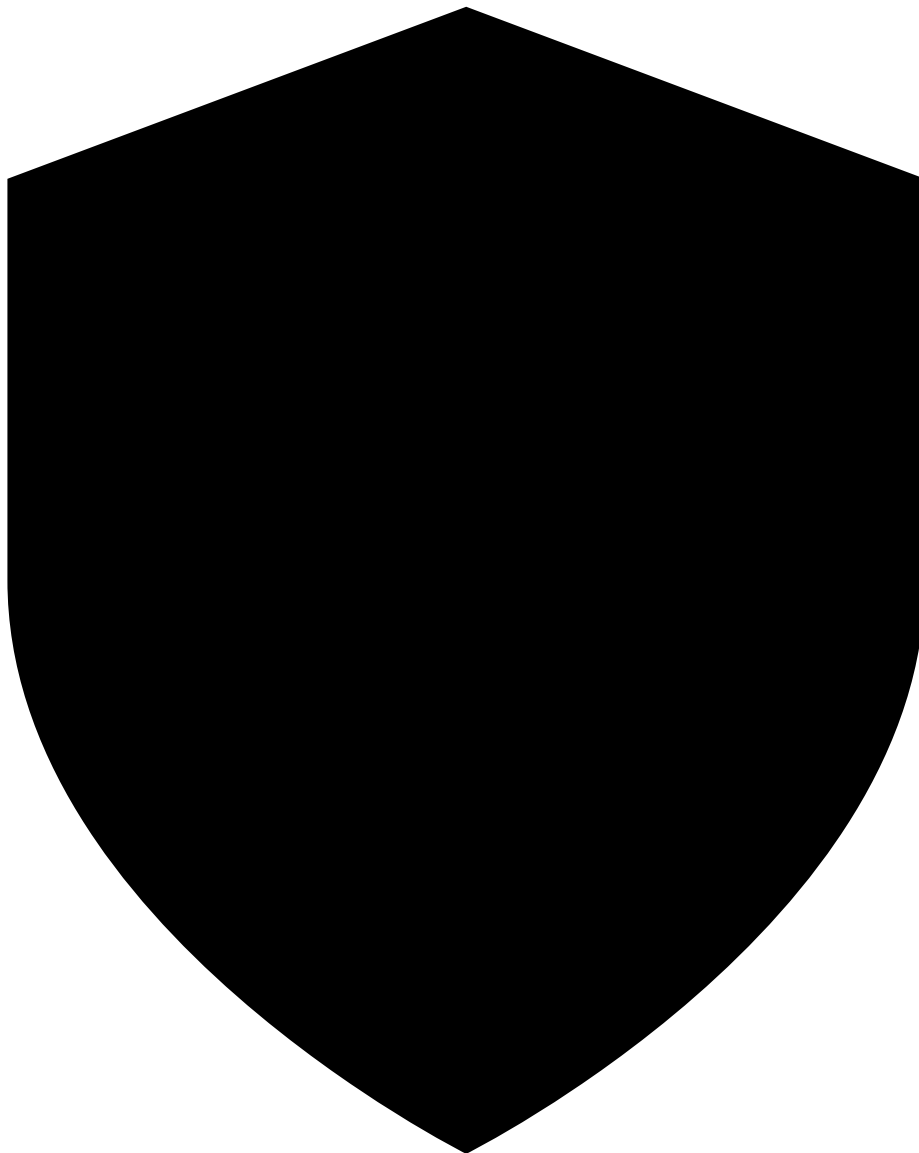
IRD number

Your tax identifier — needed to be paid correctly. Apply as soon as you arrive



KiwiSaver

Voluntary retirement savings, with employer contributions, auto-enrolled when you start work



ACC

No-fault accident cover for everyone in NZ – funded automatically via levies

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You can usually start the process online before you arrive and activate the account in person once here. You'll typically need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a New Zealand address. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Your IRD number & getting paid

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct PAYE tax code is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly into your NZ account.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out; contributions are a set percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. Funds can be withdrawn if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and fees before moving larger amounts.

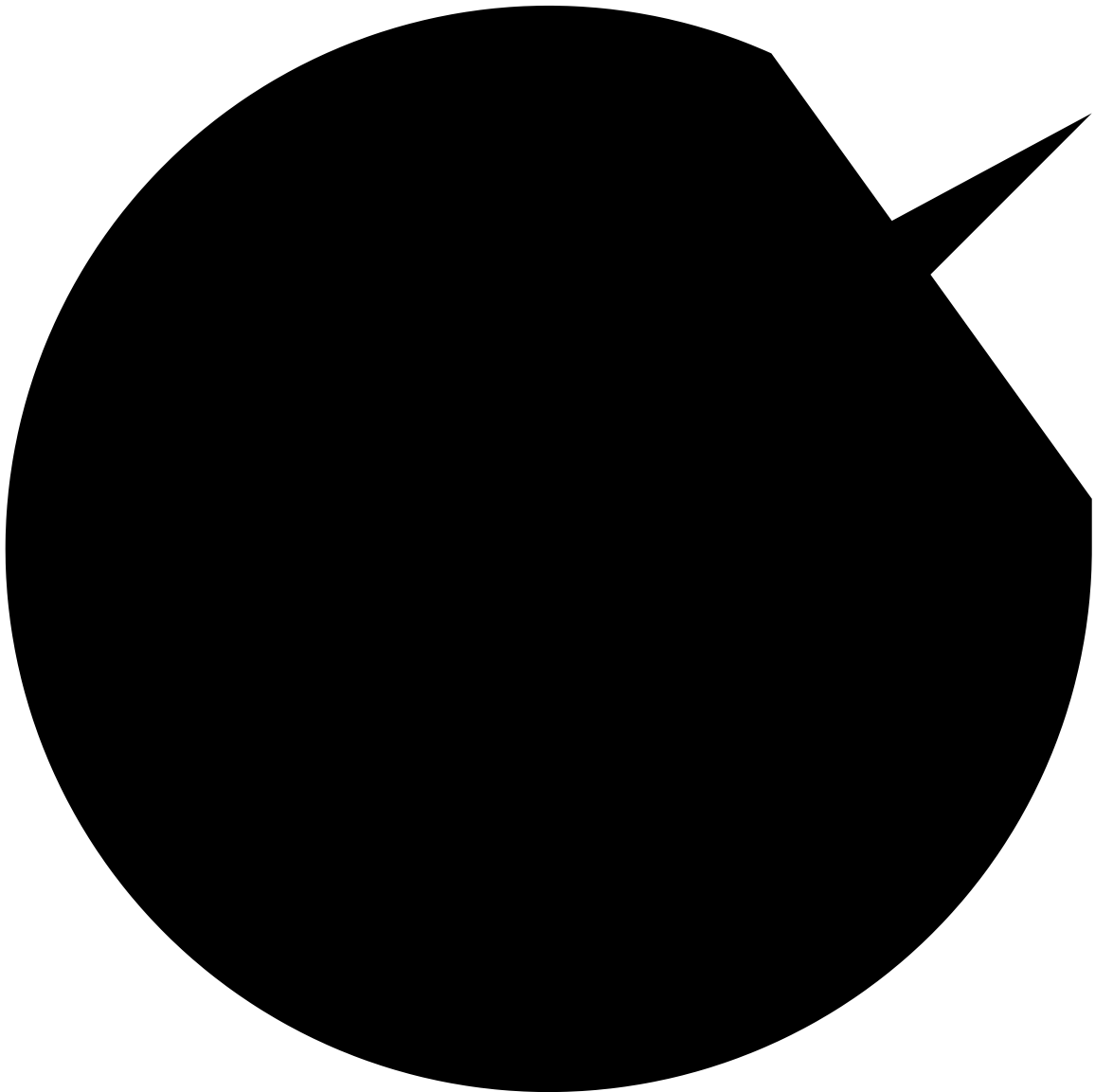
Do this first

Apply for your IRD number as soon as you arrive — almost everything else in your financial setup depends on it.

Tax, ACC & insurance

Income tax is deducted automatically through PAYE, so for most people there's nothing to file. You're taxed on income from New Zealand and overseas once you're a tax resident — Inland Revenue (IRD) has clear calculators if you want to check where you'll sit.

ACC — the Accident Compensation Corporation — gives everyone in New Zealand no-fault cover for injuries, whether they happen at work, at home or on the ski field. It's funded through levies and government, and applies to residents and visitors alike.



Worth sorting early

Insurance — ACC covers injury, but not illness or your belongings. Many newcomers take out health, contents and life cover; Immigration New Zealand publishes a migrants' guide to what's worth considering.

KiwiSaver — you become eligible once you're a resident, and it's one of the simplest ways to build long-term savings.

Work for a partner or family member

If a partner is job-hunting, New Zealand has a healthy market and a few trusted places to start.

Healthcare

Kiwi Health Jobs ↗

The national site for health and care vacancies across Aotearoa.

(<https://www.kiwihealthjobs.com/>)

All industries

Seek ↗

The largest general job board in New Zealand.

(<https://www.seek.co.nz/>)

[All industries](#)

[Trade Me Jobs ↗](#)

Broad listings across most sectors and regions.

(<https://www.trademe.co.nz/a/jobs>)

[Government](#)

[Work and Income ↗](#)

Job listings plus advice and support for new arrivals.

(<https://www.workandincome.govt.nz/>)

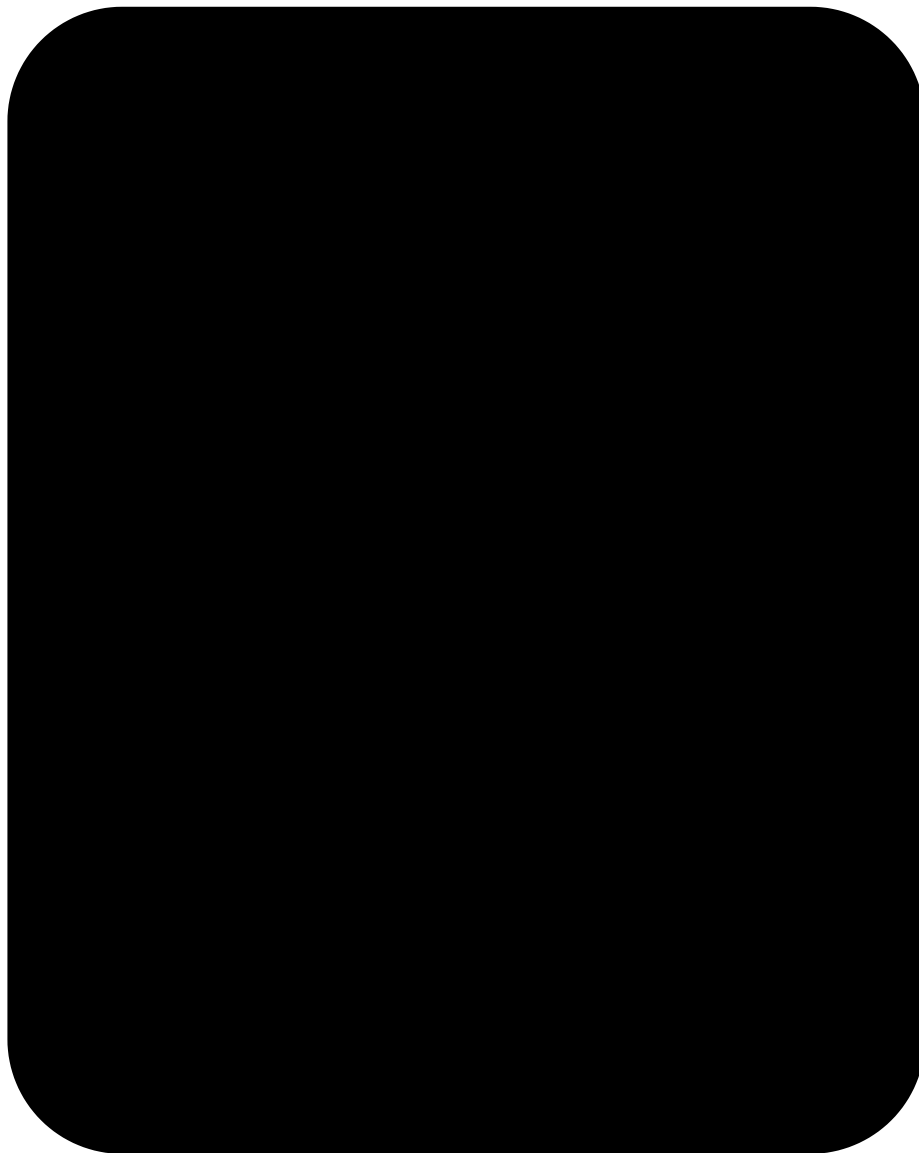
Renting in New Zealand

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 6 of 15

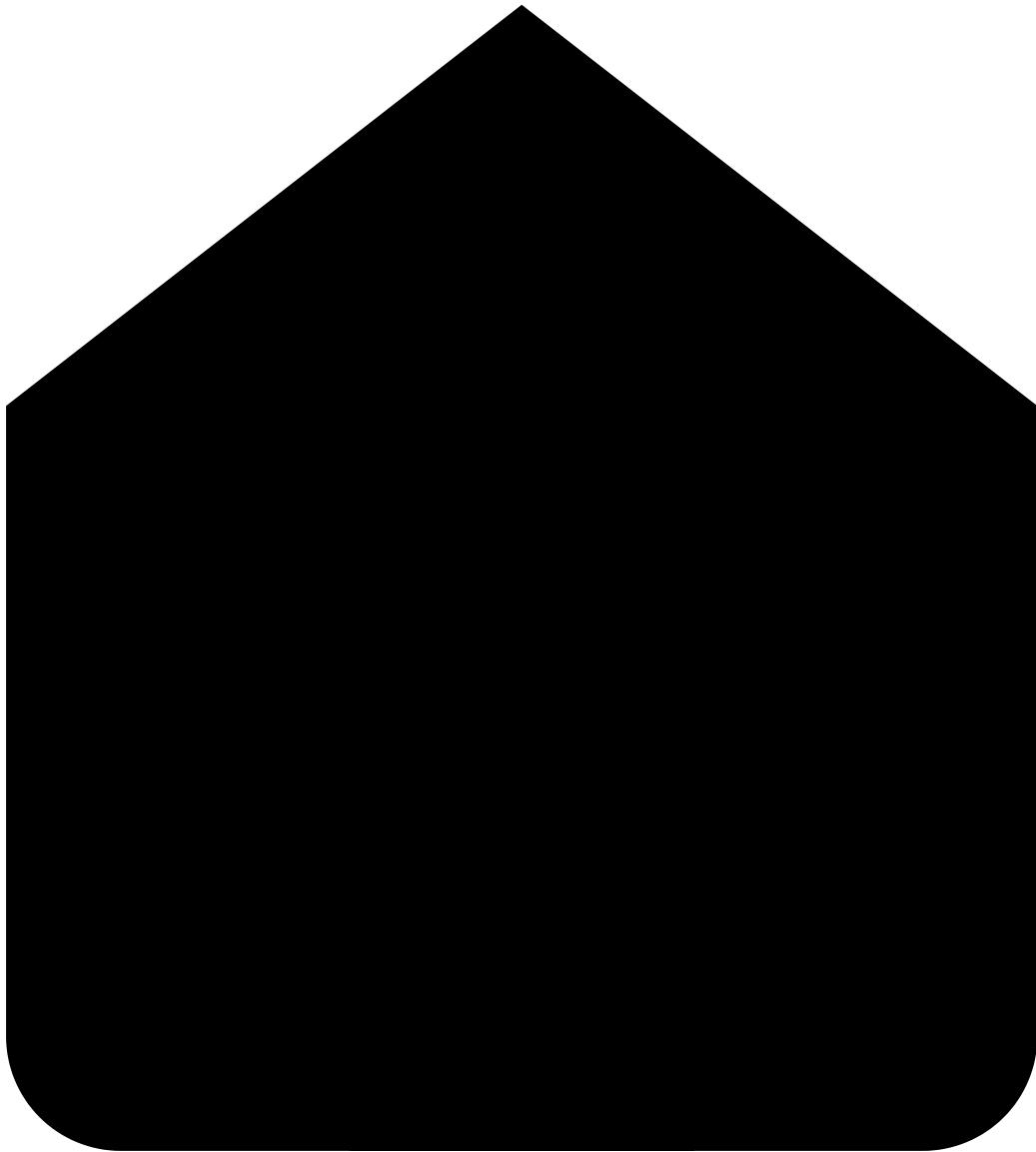
Housing ranges from city apartments to suburban homes and beachside properties. Costs vary widely by region – generally far more affordable outside Auckland and Wellington.



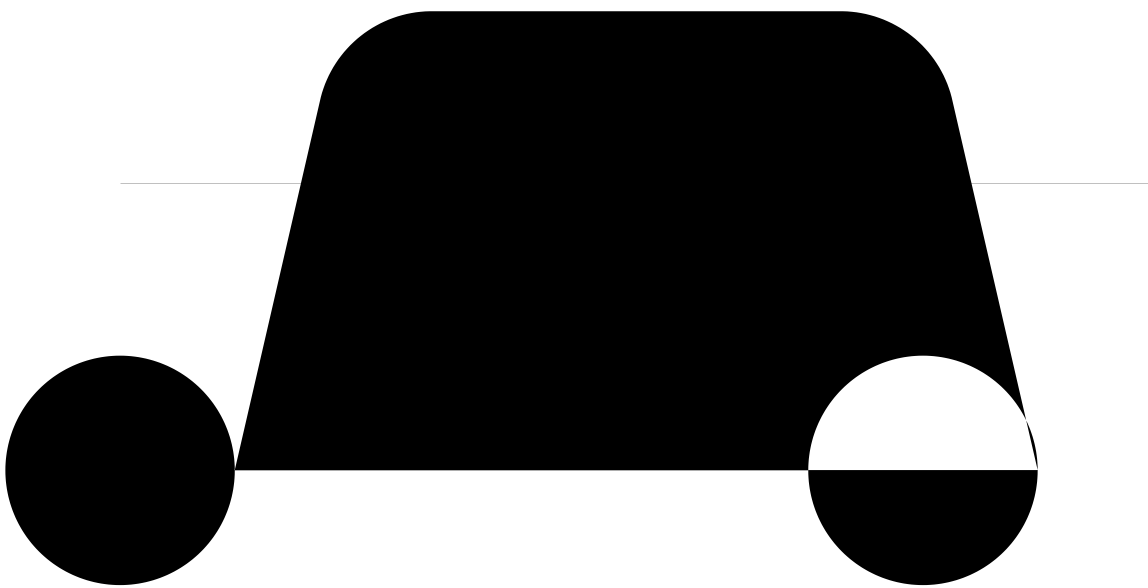
Kettle on. A longer read – about 5 min



\$300/wk
1-bed apartment (from, regional)



\$500/wk
2-3 bed house (from, regional)



Left

Side of the road you drive on

Grocery prices are consistent nationwide, with abundant fresh local produce. The lower cost of living in regional centres — paired with the country's natural and cultural offerings — makes them especially appealing for families.

Driving is on the left, and a network of well-maintained highways connects the country. Public transport is strongest in the main cities; in smaller towns a car is recommended. Utilities are straightforward to set up once you have an address.

What you'll pay to rent

Rents vary widely by region and property type. These are indicative weekly ranges to help you budget — always check current listings for your area.

Where you settle	Flatshare	1-bed	3-bed house
Major city (e.g. Auckland)	\$200–400	\$400–700	\$600–1,200
Smaller city	\$150–300	\$250–450	\$400–800
Town	\$100–250	\$200–400	\$300–600
Village / rural	\$80–200	\$150–350	\$200–500

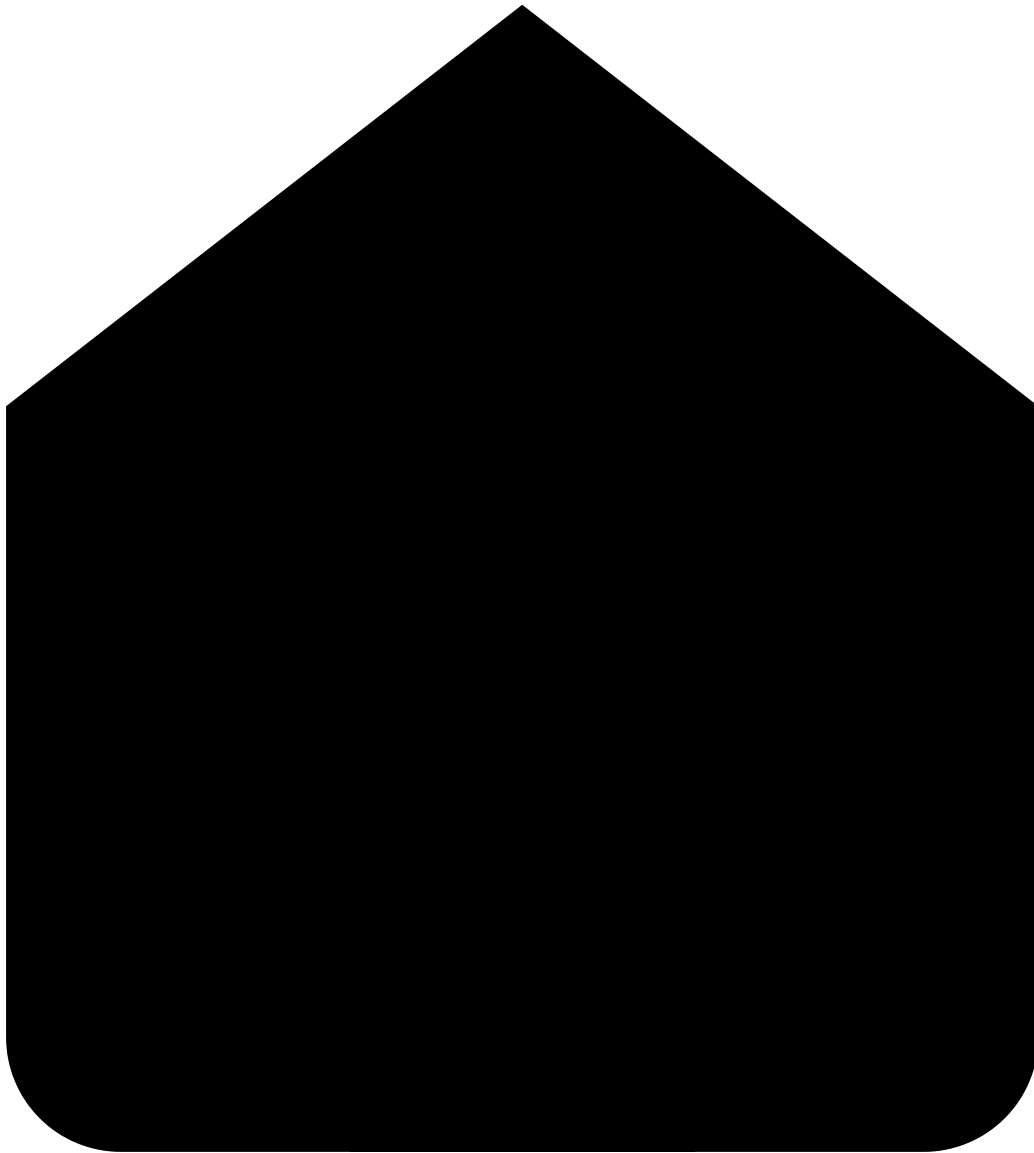
Indicative weekly rent in NZD. Most rentals are unfurnished; a bond of up to four weeks' rent is lodged with Tenancy Services and returned when you leave.

Furnishing an unfurnished rental

Most rentals come empty, which raises the question the rent table leaves open: what does it cost to fill one? Usually less than people budget for. New Zealand has a large, busy second-hand market, and most clinicians furnish gradually – a bed and the kitchen basics in the first week, the rest once they know what the house actually needs.

Item	Typical second-hand price
Sofa	\$150–800
Dining table & chairs	\$150–700
Queen bed frame	\$100–500
Mattress (most people buy this new)	\$400–1,000
Bedside tables	\$30–100 each
Chest of drawers	\$80–300
Coffee table	\$40–200
TV unit	\$50–250
Washing machine	\$250–700
Fridge freezer	\$300–900

Indicative second-hand prices in NZD. They vary by region and condition, so treat them as a starting point for a budget, not a quote. Couples who mix second-hand furniture with a new mattress and bedding tend to furnish a rental for around **NZ\$2,500–5,000** all in.



Where people look

Second-hand – Facebook Marketplace is the busiest place for local, near-new pieces; then Trade Me, Habitat for Humanity ReStores, City Mission stores, Salvation Army Family Stores and hospice shops.

New, on a budget – Mocka, Early Settler and Furniture Clearance Centre sell starter pieces and packages at gentler prices than the premium retailers, for the few things you would rather buy new.

Locally – most regions have a well-loved used-furniture dealer. New colleagues will know the nearest one.

“I spent ages deciding what to ship and what to leave behind. In the end, the cost of shipping some of our furniture was more than it was worth. There’s so much available second-hand in New Zealand through Facebook Marketplace and Trade Me. We arrived with far less than we originally planned and just bought things as we needed them.”

A CLINICIAN ON WHAT THEY SHIPPED, AND WHAT THEY LEFT BEHIND

Our view

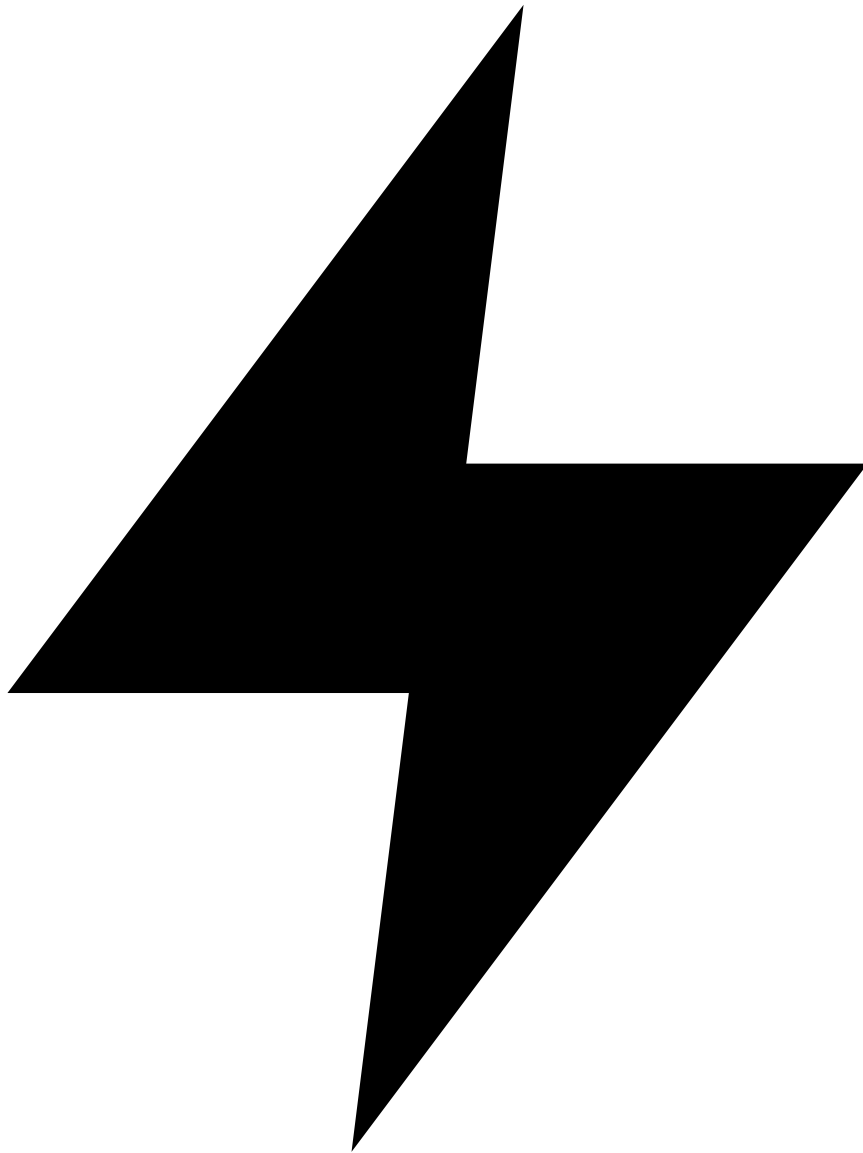
The misconception we hear most is that the house needs to be furnished by day one. Building it gradually costs less, and it means you are not buying a sofa for a suburb you may not stay in. Our advice is usually to arrive with less than you planned and buy as you go.

The cost of everyday life



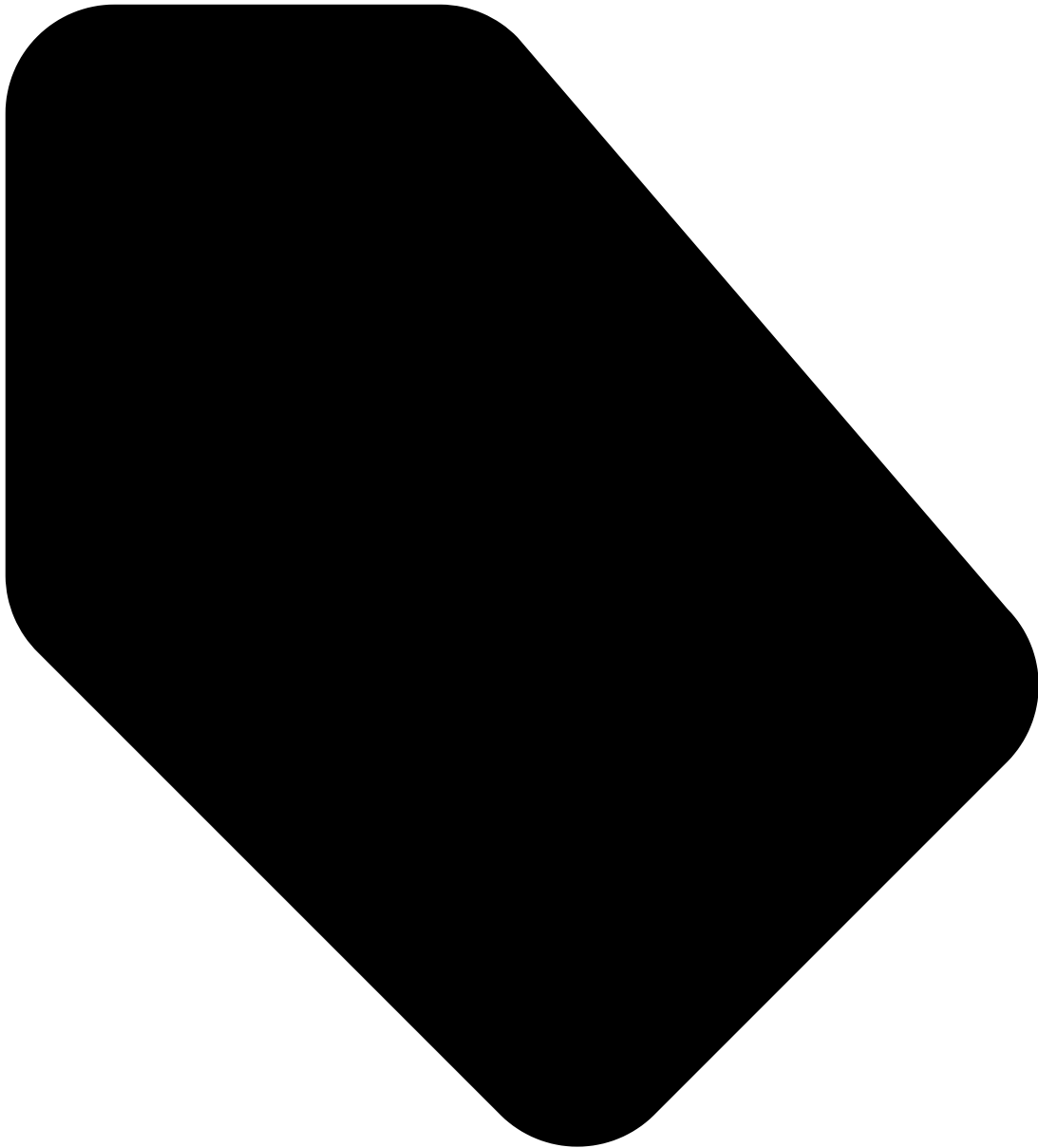
Groceries

Prices are fairly consistent nationwide. Budget supermarkets like Pak'nSave are cheapest; New World and specialty stores sit higher. Fresh local produce is excellent.



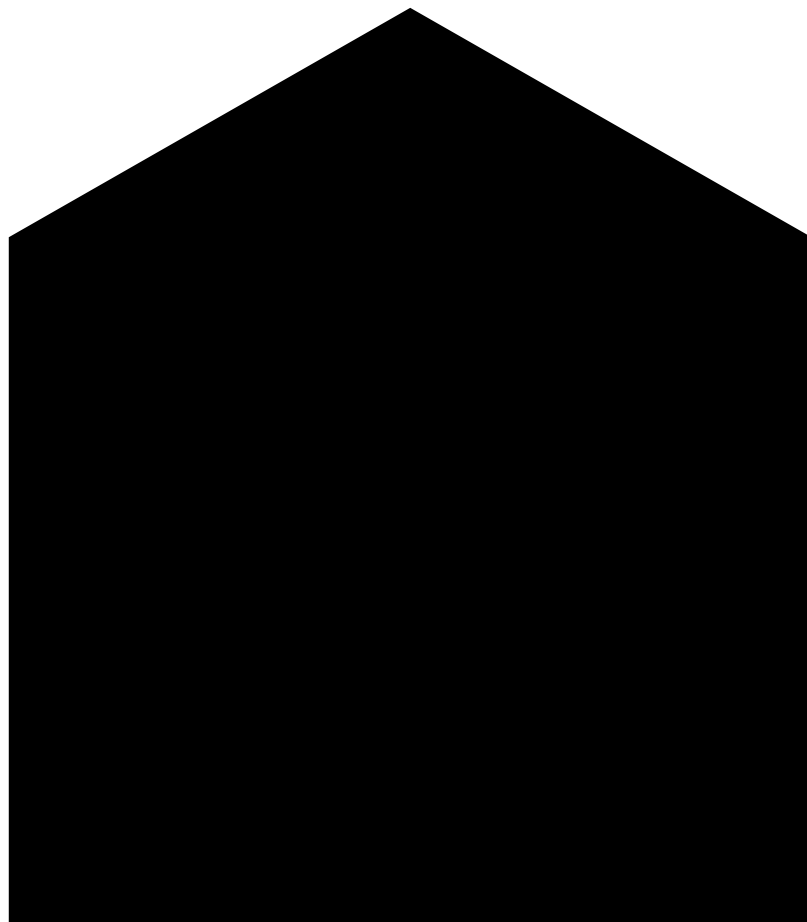
Utilities

Power, internet and phone are quick to set up once you have an address — comparison sites make switching providers easy.



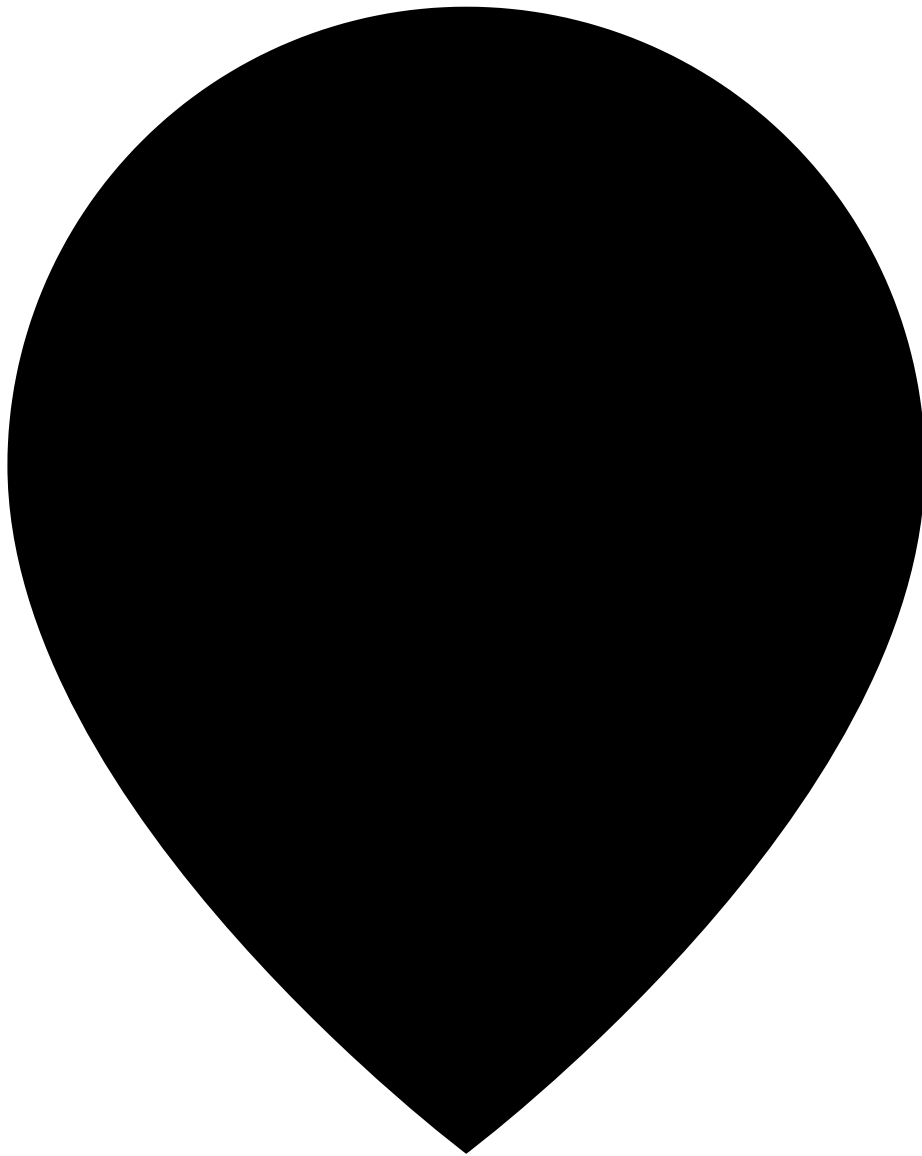
Where it's cheaper

Regional centres cost noticeably less than Auckland and Wellington, especially on housing.



Day-to-day banking

EFTPOS is used everywhere, and most pay arrives by fortnightly direct credit.



A few of the things on your doorstep

The outdoors – hiking and tramping (the Great Walks are world-famous), skiing in the Southern Alps, mountain biking, kayaking and surf beaches.

Wildlife & wide skies – whale watching at Kaikōura, some of the Southern Hemisphere's best stargazing, and native birdlife found nowhere else.

Food, wine & culture – Marlborough and Central Otago wine regions, a strong café culture, festivals, and a sporting life built around rugby, cricket and netball.

Faith & community

New Zealand is religiously diverse and tolerant. Churches of many denominations sit alongside mosques, temples, gurdwaras and synagogues in the main centres, and there's an easy acceptance of those who follow no faith at all.

Education & schools in New Zealand

For many families, the children's schooling is the question that matters most.

Moving to New Zealand · **Chapter 7 of 15** All 15 chapters →

PAGE AT A GLANCE



Kettle on. A longer read – about 15 min

1. [The stages of school](#)
2. [School year & holidays](#)
3. [Types of school](#)
4. [Enrolment & zones](#)
5. [Curriculum & NCEA](#)
6. [What it costs](#)
7. [School uniforms](#)
8. [Childcare & clubs](#)
9. [Helping children settle](#)
10. [Common questions](#)

THE REASSURING PART

A welcoming system where children settle fast

New Zealand's education system is well regarded and inclusive, and schools here are used to welcoming children from all over the world. Families often tell us their children settled faster than they did.

The system will feel broadly familiar to anyone from a comparable country, with a few differences in structure, qualifications and the way you enrol. This guide walks through all of it, so you can picture your children's school days clearly and choose the right place with confidence.

If there's one practical thing to take away, it's this: **school enrolment and where you live are closely linked**. Many good schools have enrolment zones, so it pays to research schools before you settle on a neighbourhood, often the school decides the postcode.

FROM TODDLERS TO TEENAGERS

The stages of education

Schooling runs from age 5 through to around 18, divided into clear stages. Most children start school on or around their fifth birthday, and education is compulsory from 6 to 16.

Under 5

Early childhood (ECE)

birth–5

Optional but popular early learning: kindergartens, daycare, playcentres and kōhanga reo (Māori-language). Government funding subsidises a set number of hours a week for children aged 3 to 5, so it's more affordable than many expect.

Years 1–6

Primary school

ages 5–10

The foundation years, starting when your child turns five. Warm, play-informed and broad, with a strong focus on literacy, numeracy and learning to belong in a classroom community.

Years 7–8

Intermediate

ages 11–12

A two-year bridge between primary and secondary in many areas, easing the step up. In some places these years sit within a full primary or a middle school instead, it varies by region.

Years 9–13

Secondary (college / high school)

ages 13–17

Where students work towards their national qualifications in the senior years, with a widening choice of subjects and pathways into work, training or university.

HOW THE YEAR IS SHAPED

The school year & holidays

The New Zealand school year runs from late January to mid-December, divided into four terms of roughly ten weeks each. Between terms are two-week breaks, with a long summer holiday over Christmas and New Year.

TERM 1

Late Jan – mid-April

The year begins, usually in the first week or two of February, followed by a two-week autumn break.

TERM 2

Early May – early July

The longest stretch of settled learning, rounded off by the two-week winter holidays.

TERM 3

Mid-July – late Sept

Through the heart of winter into early spring, then a two-week spring break.

TERM 4

Mid-Oct – mid-Dec

The final term, ending before Christmas and the long summer holiday of around six weeks.

A few things worth knowing: **exact dates are set each year by the Ministry of Education and vary slightly between schools** (start days, the odd teacher-only day). Public holidays and your region's anniversary day also fall within term time. For care over the breaks, holiday programmes are widely available, see [childcare & out-of-school care](#) above.

YOUR CHOICES

The types of school

Most children attend free, government-funded state schools, but there are three main types to know about: each with a different character and cost.

Most common

State schools

Government-funded and free for domestic students, these educate the large majority of children. Quality is generally high and consistent, and they follow the national curriculum.

Special character

State-integrated

State-funded schools with a particular character, often faith-based (such as Catholic) or a specific philosophy. They follow the national curriculum but usually charge modest attendance dues.

Fee-paying

Private / independent

Independently run and funded mainly through fees. A smaller part of the system, chosen by some families for particular programmes, facilities or smaller classes.

THE THING TO GET RIGHT EARLY

Enrolment zones, why where you live matters

Many popular schools manage demand with an enrolment zone. Inside it, a place is generally guaranteed; outside it, places are limited and offered by ballot – which is the single biggest reason to research schools before choosing where to live.

In-zone

Living within a school's zone usually guarantees enrolment, which is why families often choose the neighbourhood for the school.

Out-of-zone

Out-of-zone places at popular schools are limited and typically allocated by a ballot, so they're never guaranteed.

Check before you commit

You can look up any school's zone online before signing a lease. A few minutes here saves a lot of stress later.

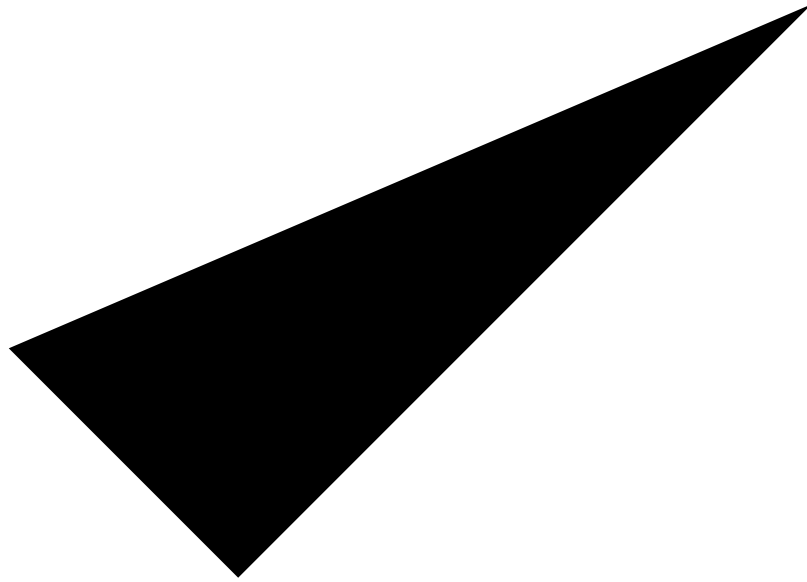
“Ethicare advised us to choose our children’s school before looking for a home, because many schools in New Zealand are zoned. It was really useful advice. We found that rental prices could vary quite a bit depending on the school zone, although we were pleasantly surprised by how good the standard of schools was generally. It definitely helped us narrow down where we wanted to live.”

A family we supported, on choosing the school before the suburb

GETTING ENROLLED

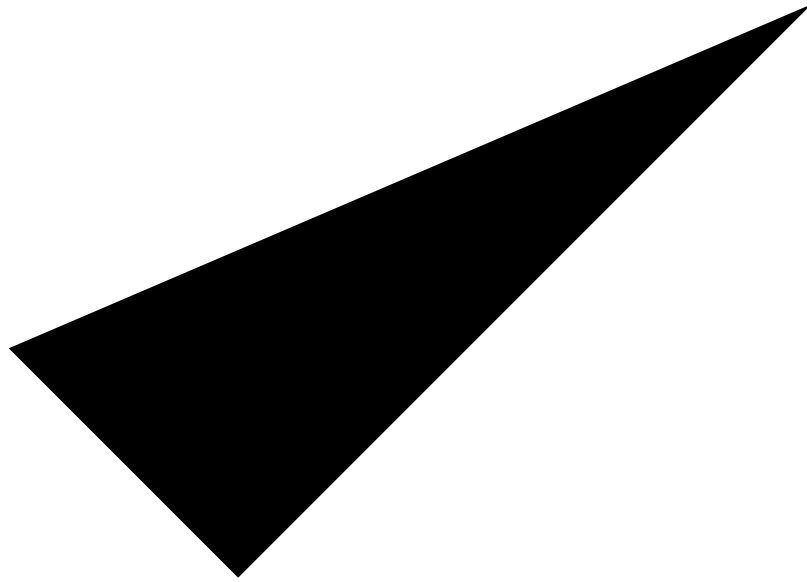
How enrolment works

The practical steps are straightforward, and schools are helpful with new arrivals. A few things worth knowing as you go.



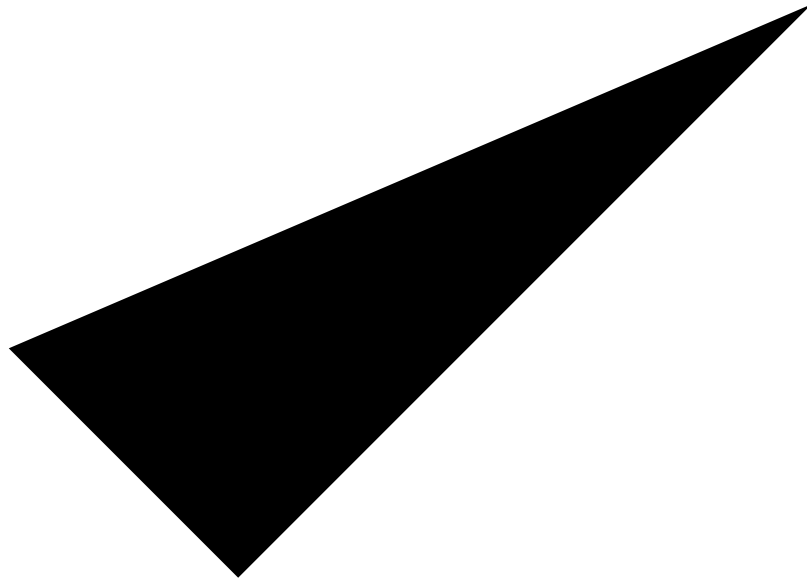
Contact the school directly

You enrol with the individual school rather than a central authority. Reach out before you arrive if you can: many will start the conversation by email.



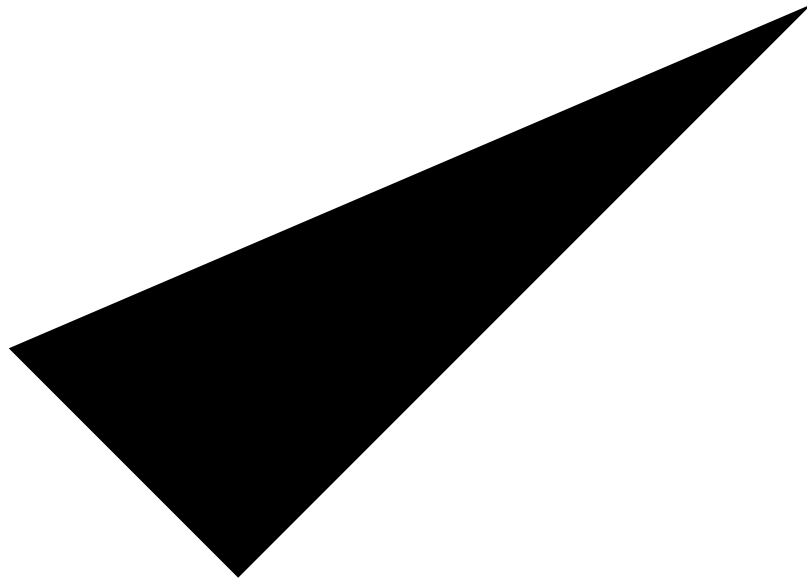
Bring your documents

Have passports, visas, immunisation records, and your children's previous school reports and any learning-support paperwork ready, they help with the right placement.



Year level follows age

Children are generally placed by age rather than by exactly where they were in their old system, which keeps them with their peers.



Extra language support

Schools provide English-language learning support where it's needed, so children who are still building their English are well looked after.

WHAT THEY'LL LEARN & EARN

Curriculum & qualifications

A broad, inclusive curriculum runs through the school years, and senior students work towards a national qualification, with some schools offering international alternatives too.

The curriculum

Broad & inclusive

Schools follow the New Zealand Curriculum, with te reo Māori and Aotearoa's bicultural heritage woven through. The emphasis is on well-rounded learning, not just exams, including plenty of time outdoors and on sport.

The main qualification

NCEA

The National Certificate of Educational Achievement is the principal secondary qualification, taken across the final three years (Levels 1–3). It's flexible, combining internal and external assessment across a wide range of subjects.

Other options

Cambridge & IB

Some schools also offer Cambridge International or the International Baccalaureate alongside or instead of NCEA, worth asking about if your child is mid-pathway or you'd like an internationally portable qualification.

NCEA is assessed in credits across the senior years rather than in one set of final exams, which is the biggest adjustment for a teenager arriving mid-schooling.

TOLD STRAIGHT

What it costs

State schooling is free for domestic students, but there are everyday extras to budget for, and your visa decides whether your children are treated as domestic or international students.

State school tuition

Free for domestic students, which children of many longer-term work-visa holders are, depending on the visa.

School donations

State schools may request a voluntary donation to top up funding. It's optional, though many families contribute.

Uniforms, stationery & devices

Practical costs you'll budget for: uniforms, stationery, a device for older students, and trips or activities.

State-integrated dues

Integrated schools typically charge modest compulsory attendance dues on top of the free tuition.

Private school fees

Independent schools charge full tuition fees, which vary widely by school.

International student fees

If your visa means your children are international students, state schools charge fees, so it's worth confirming your status early.

Whether your children count as domestic or international students depends on your visa. Confirm it with Immigration New Zealand or the school. Rules and costs change, so always check the current position at the source. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not an education authority.

WHAT THEY'LL WEAR

School uniforms

Whether your child wears a uniform depends mostly on their age and the school. As a rule, the older the student, the more likely a uniform, and the more formal it tends to be.

Primary years

Often simple, sometimes none

Many primary schools have a relaxed, inexpensive uniform. Usually a polo and shorts, skirt or trousers in the school colours, and some have none at all. Summers are casual, and it's common for young children to go barefoot on warm days.

Intermediate & secondary

Usually compulsory

From intermediate and especially at secondary school, a uniform is normally required, often with a separate PE kit. State-integrated and private schools tend to be more formal, sometimes including a blazer.

Sun-smart

Hats in summer

New Zealand takes sun protection seriously. Many schools run a "no hat, no play" rule through the summer terms, so a wide-brim or bucket hat is usually part of the kit.

Where to buy uniforms

- **The school's own uniform shop or office.** The first stop, and where compulsory branded items are sold.
- **The school's approved uniform supplier,** many schools nominate a specialist supplier for items like blazers, jerseys and the PE kit.
- **Big-box retailers such as The Warehouse,** handy and affordable for generic basics: plain polos, shorts, socks, hats and shoes.
- **Second-hand uniform sales,** run by most schools or their parents' association, and by far the cheapest way to kit children out.

FOR THE UNDER-FIVES & AFTER THE BELL

Childcare & out-of-school care

Whether you've got pre-schoolers or school-age children, there's a well-established system to help working parents, funded early learning, before- and after-school care, and clubs that cover the gaps around your shifts.

20 Hours ECE

The government's 20 Hours ECE scheme funds up to 20 hours a week of early childhood education for eligible children aged three to five (and some younger children at certain services), at participating providers. It makes pre-school care far more affordable than many newcomers expect.

Extra help with costs

Beyond the funded hours, families may be able to get further help, such as a Childcare Subsidy through Work and Income, depending on income, hours worked and circumstances. It's worth checking what you're eligible for once you've arrived.

Finding a place

Options include kindergartens, daycare (education & care centres), home-based care, playcentres and kōhanga reo. Popular centres can have waitlists, so enquire early. Ideally before you arrive, to line something up for your start date.

Childcare near work

Some hospital and healthcare sites have an onsite or nearby early learning centre, though it isn't universal. If childcare close to work matters for your shifts, tell us, we can check what's available at a specific site.

Breakfast clubs

Many schools take part in a national breakfast programme, providing a free, healthy breakfast before class. It's a quiet help on busy mornings and a warm start to the day for children settling in.

Before & after-school care

Out of School Care and Recreation (OSCAR) programmes run before school, after school and through the holidays, often onsite or nearby. A Work and Income OSCAR Subsidy can help with the cost for eligible families, useful when your hours don't match the school bell.

Funding rules, hours and subsidies change and depend on your circumstances and visa, always confirm the current detail with the Ministry of Education, Work and Income or the provider. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not an education authority, but we're glad to help you weigh up options near a role.

Early learning here is play-based and part-funded from age three — the constraint is usually places rather than price, and the waiting list starts before you land.

MORE THAN LOGISTICS

Helping your children settle

Enrolment is the easy part; helping a child feel at home is the real work. Happily, New Zealand's school culture does much of the heavy lifting, but a little intention helps.

Younger children

Tend to settle within weeks. Friendly classrooms, lots of outdoor play and sport make it easy to make friends fast, often before their parents have unpacked the last box.

Teenagers

May need more time and more say. Leaving friends at a decisive age is hard, so involve them in school choice, keep talking, and give the first term or two to find their feet.

Lean on the school

Schools are experienced at welcoming new arrivals and often pair newcomers with a buddy. Get to know teachers early, and the school gate is a great place for parents to make friends too.

Sophie's insight

The children are so often the part parents worry about most, and so often the ones who settle first. My one piece of practical advice is to start with the school, not the suburb: find schools you'd be happy with, check their zones, and let that guide where you look to live. And don't underestimate a Kiwi childhood: the outdoors, the sport, the easygoing classrooms. Plenty of families tell me their kids ended up happier here than they ever expected.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions parents ask us

Will my children need a school uniform, and what does it cost?—

It depends on the school and the age. Primary schools are often relaxed, a simple, inexpensive uniform or none at all, while intermediate and secondary schools usually require one, sometimes with a separate PE kit. It's a cost worth budgeting for upfront, but most schools run second-hand uniform sales that bring it right down. See our [uniforms section above](#) for the detail.

Can my children go to state school for free on my visa?+

What childcare is available for under-fives, and is it subsidised?+

When in the year should my child start school?+

OFFICIAL SOURCES

Where to check the detail

These official sites carry the current detail, for finding schools, checking zones and reports, and understanding qualifications.

Find & choose a school

Schools, zones & reports

Find a school & check zones

(<https://www.educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school>)

Education Review Office (ERO)

(<https://ero.govt.nz>)

Information for parents

(<https://parents.education.govt.nz>)

Qualifications

NCEA & senior study

NZQA · qualifications

(<https://www.nzqa.govt.nz>)

Understanding NCEA

(<https://ncea.education.govt.nz>)

Study in New Zealand

(<https://www.studyinnewzealand.govt.nz>)

The system & curriculum

How schooling is run

Ministry of Education

(<https://www.education.govt.nz>)

The New Zealand Curriculum

(<https://newzealandcurriculum.tahurangi.education.govt.nz>)

Early childhood education

(<https://www.education.govt.nz/early-childhood>)

Your children's status as domestic or international students depends on your visa. Confirm with Immigration New Zealand. Details change, so always check the current position at the source.

KEEP EXPLORING

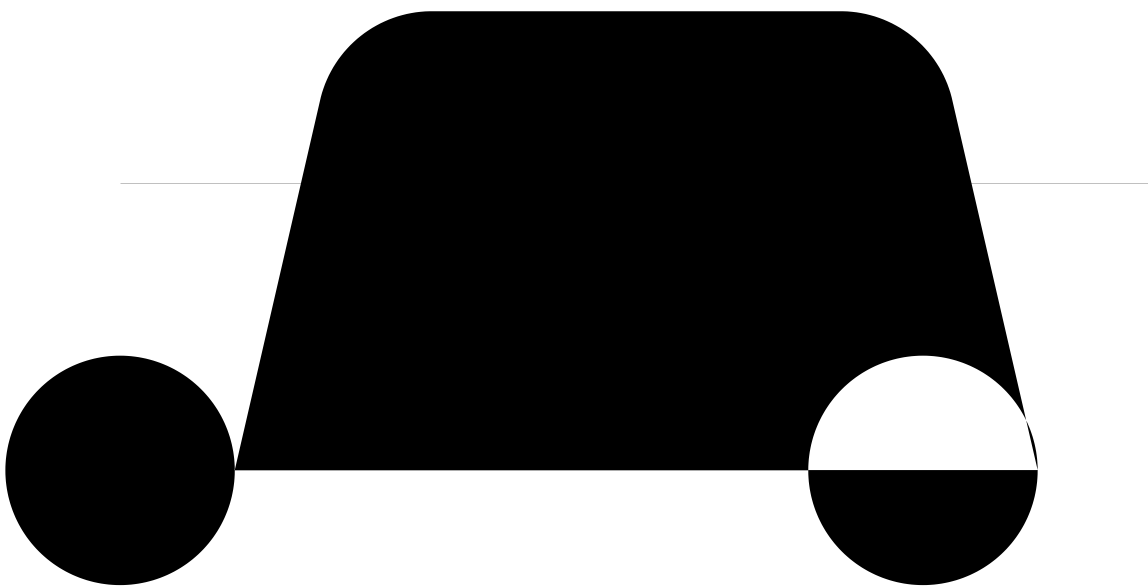
Related guides

[Previous](#)[Renting in New Zealand](#)[All chapters](#)[Next](#)[Driving & licences](#)

Driving & licences

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 8 of 15

New Zealanders drive on the left. Many new arrivals can drive on their overseas licence for a period before converting to a NZ one.



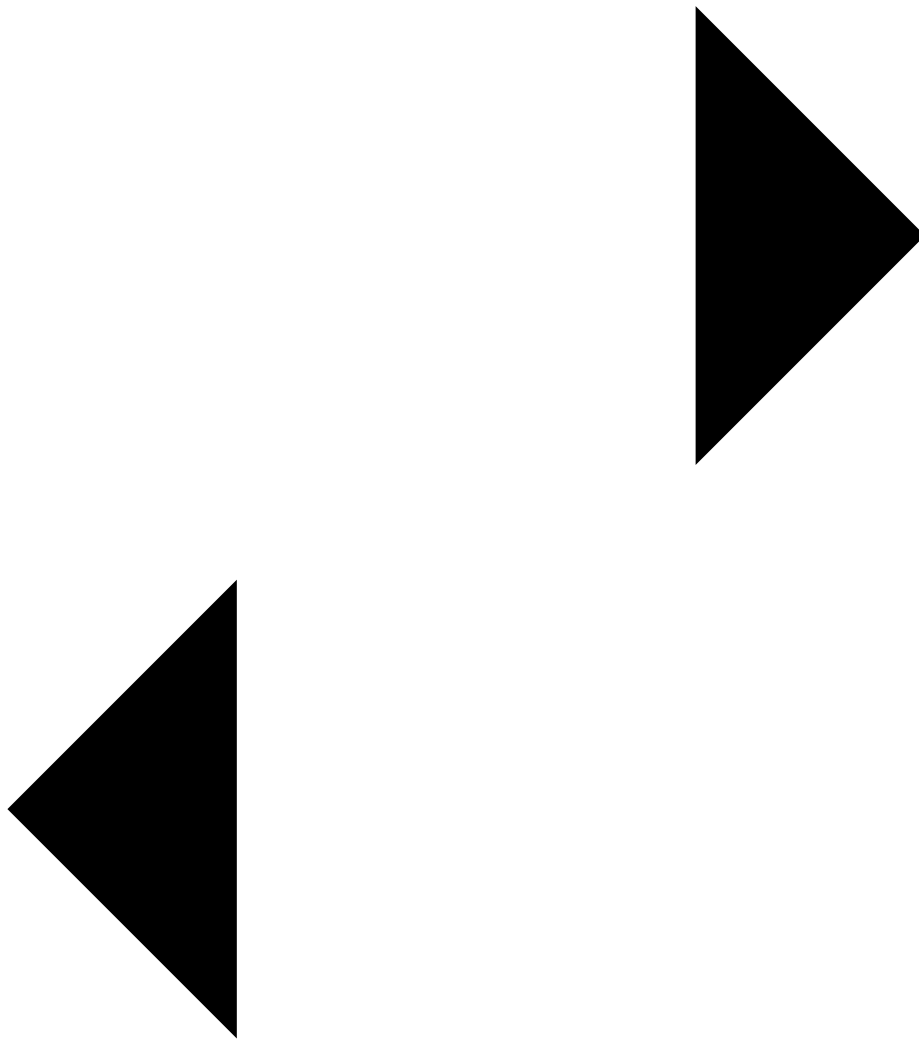
Drive on the left

Give way rules and roundabouts run clockwise – take care in your first weeks



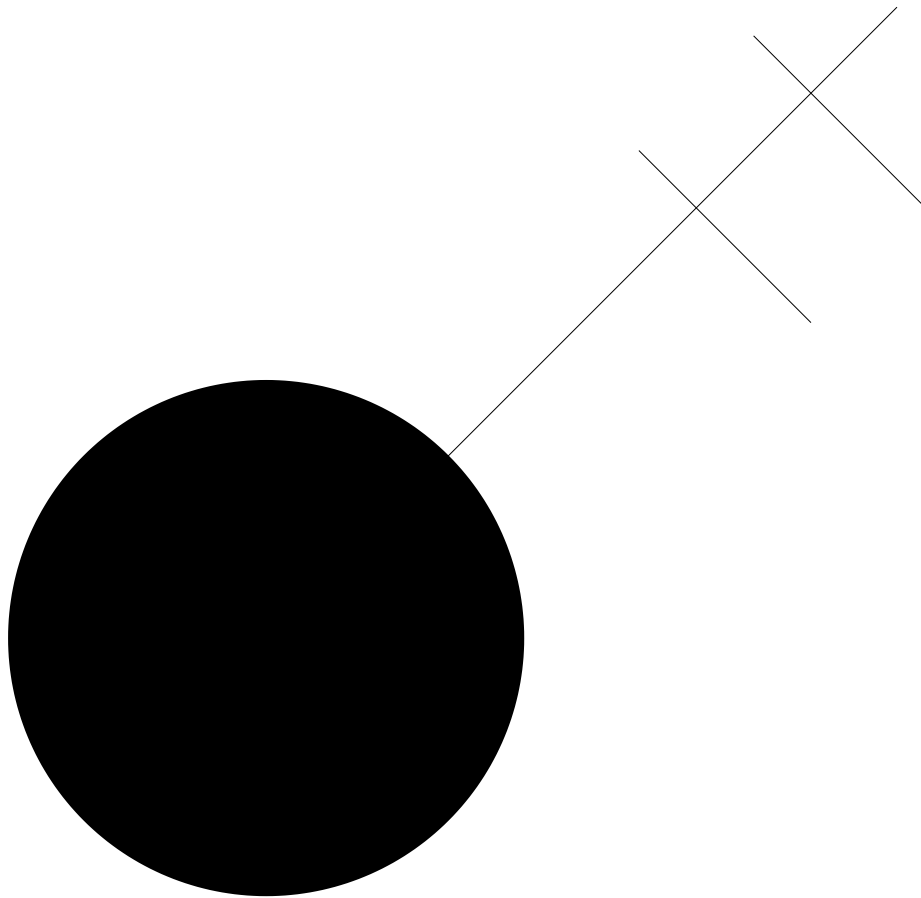
Overseas licence

You can usually drive on a valid overseas (or international) licence for up to 12 months



Converting

After that, convert to a NZ licence – some countries convert directly, others require tests



Buying a car

Vehicles need a current WoF (warrant of fitness) and registration to be legal on the road



Good to know before you drive

Roads can be narrow, winding and rural — journey times are often longer than the distance suggests

Always carry your licence; overseas licences must be in English or carry an official translation

The AA offers roadside assistance, licensing help and vehicle inspections nationwide

Drink-driving limits are strict and enforced — plan ahead on nights out

[Official](#)



Licence conversion, the road code and everything about driving legally in NZ.

(<https://www.nzta.govt.nz/driver-licences/>)

Support



Roadside assistance, licensing, and vehicle inspections across the country.

(<https://www.aa.co.nz/>)

Immigration & visas

How visas work for healthcare professionals, the main pathways, plainly explained, and where each one leads.

Kettle on. A longer read — about 11 min

Moving to New Zealand · **Chapter 9 of 15** All 15 chapters →

— WHAT DO YOU NEED HELP WITH?

Three things you can do right now

Pick the one you need now. The full guide is underneath for when you have a cup of tea and half an hour.

I want to know what it will cost

Price up the move

Visa fees, flights, shipping and the first month here, worked out for your household rather than a generic average.

Open the cost calculator I want the official immigration links

Get the official links

Immigration New Zealand, the Green List and the forms you'll actually need, gathered in one place.

Open the directory I want someone to sequence it with me

Talk it through

We explain the routes and keep your file moving. The decisions stay with Immigration New Zealand, but you won't be guessing at the order.

Ask us about your visa

— THE SHORT VERSION

The visa usually follows the job, not the other way around

Reviewed July 2026 · checked against Immigration New Zealand's current published guidance.
Immigration rules change, always confirm at the source

Immigration is where most people expect the first hurdle. In practice it tends to fall into place once you have a job offer from a New Zealand employer — the offer is the key that unlocks the visa.

New Zealand has deliberately built fast, welcoming routes for the skills it needs most, and healthcare is high on that list. The **Green List** sets out in-demand roles with streamlined pathways to residence, and many of the professions we place are on it. That changes the whole feeling of this step: not a battle to be allowed in, but a country making it straightforward for you to stay.

One honest note up front: **Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not licensed immigration advisers**. What we offer is hard-won familiarity with these pathways and employers who are accredited to support visas, and where you need formal immigration advice, we'll make sure you get it from the right people.

HOW IT FITS TOGETHER

Three pieces that move together

Registration, your job offer and your visa aren't a strict queue, they progress alongside one another. Holding all three in mind from the start is what keeps the move smooth.

The offer

A job with an accredited employer

Most work visas require a job offer from an employer accredited by Immigration New Zealand. The employers we work with hold that accreditation, which is what makes the visa possible.

The visa

The right route for you

With an offer in hand, the question becomes which visa fits, a work visa to begin, or, for Green List roles, often a direct route towards residence.

The future

A pathway to residence

For many healthcare roles the destination isn't a temporary stay but residence, the security of putting down roots, which is exactly what most families are really after.

WHY HEALTHCARE HAS IT EASIER

The Green List, in plain terms

The Green List names the roles New Zealand is actively short of. If your profession is on it the pathway is faster and clearer, and it comes in two tiers depending on the role.

Tier 1

Straight to Residence

Residence from the outset

For the most in-demand roles, you can apply for residence directly with a qualifying job offer, rather than working for years first. It's the most secure footing you can arrive on.

Residence application from the start

Includes your partner and dependent children

The strongest sense of permanence from day one

Tier 2

Work to Residence

Residence after a period of work

For other Green List roles, you work in the role for a set period and can then apply for residence. You arrive on a work visa, settle in, and the residence pathway opens up as you go.

Begin on an Accredited Employer Work Visa

Apply for residence after the qualifying period

Your family comes with you from the start

Which tier is my profession?

The Green List is set by Immigration New Zealand and reviewed periodically, so roles and tiers can change. The honest, current answer for your specific profession is something we'll confirm with you directly, and you can always check the source at immigration.govt.nz.

THE MAIN ROUTES

The visas you're most likely to meet

There are several visa types, but for healthcare professionals moving with Ethicare, a handful come up again and again. Here's what each one is, in everyday language.

The usual starting point

Accredited Employer Work Visa

The main work visa, tied to a job offer from an accredited employer. For many people it's how they first arrive and begin working, with a residence pathway following on.

Green List · Tier 1

Straight to Residence Visa

For eligible Green List roles with a qualifying job offer: apply for residence directly, bringing your partner and children with you.

Green List · Tier 2

Work to Residence

Work in a qualifying Green List role for the required period, then apply for residence. A settled, staged route to putting down roots.

For your family

Partner & dependent visas

Your partner can often apply for a work visa and your children for student visas, so the whole family moves and settles together rather than apart.

Visa categories, criteria and names are set by Immigration New Zealand and can change. This is an orientation, not immigration advice. Always confirm current detail at [immigration.govt.nz](https://www.immigration.govt.nz) (<https://www.immigration.govt.nz>) or with a licensed adviser.

YOU MOVE AS A FAMILY

Bringing your partner and children

One of the quiet reassurances of these pathways is that they're built for families, not just individuals. You won't be heading out alone to send for everyone later, you move together.

Your partner can usually work

Partners of skilled migrants are often eligible for an open work visa, free to work for any employer. For many couples that's a huge relief: two careers, not one on hold.

Your children can study

Dependent children can generally study here, often as domestic students at state schools depending on your visa. Enrolment is straightforward and schools are used to welcoming new arrivals.

Residence covers everyone

Where your pathway leads to residence, it's a family residence, the security of a shared future here, with the same rights and the same roots for all of you.

THE VISA JOURNEY

How the process usually unfolds

Every case differs, but the path from offer to arrival tends to follow the same broad shape. Seeing it laid out takes most of the worry out of it.

1

Secure a job offer

An offer from an accredited employer is the foundation everything else rests on. This is where we focus first, because once it's in place the visa options become clear.

2

Confirm your pathway

Together with the right advice, you identify the visa that fits: work visa, Straight to Residence or Work to Residence, based on your role, the Green List and your circumstances.

3

Gather your evidence

Passport, qualifications, job offer, registration progress, and health and character checks such as medicals and police certificates. Starting these early avoids the most common delays.

4

Submit the application

Your application, and your family's, goes to Immigration New Zealand with the relevant fees. From here it's an assessment and processing period.

5

Approval & planning your arrival

Once granted, you can firm up flights, timing and the practical move. This is where *Preparing to move* takes over from the paperwork.

Sophie's insight

People brace themselves for the visa to be the hardest part, and for healthcare professionals it's so often the smoothest, because New Zealand has gone out of its way to make it so. My one piece of advice is to take the health and character checks seriously and start them early; a delayed medical or a slow police certificate is what trips people up, never the welcome itself. Get the right immigration advice, lean on us for the employer side, and you'll be surprised how quietly this step resolves.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

— IN THEIR WORDS

What this step felt like

Three clinicians on the moment immigration stopped being an idea and became real.

“Getting the job offer was exciting. Getting the work visa approved was the moment I knew I was actually moving to New Zealand.”

On the moment it became real

“I had assumed I would need to work in New Zealand for several years before I could even think about residence. Finding out there was a direct pathway for my profession was a very pleasant surprise.”

On the direct pathway to residence

“For me, residency meant security. I was moving my children to the other side of the world, so I needed to know there was a realistic long-term future for us in New Zealand.”

On what residency means for a family

THE HONEST PART

What's worth knowing before you apply

None of these are reasons to hesitate, they're the things that keep a visa on track rather than catching you out partway through.

1

Rules can and do change

Visa categories, the Green List and criteria are reviewed over time. Always confirm the current position at the source, and don't rely on what was true for a friend a year or two ago.

2

Health & character checks take time

Medicals and police certificates from every country you've lived in can be slow to obtain. They're routine, but they reward an early start more than almost anything else.

3

There are costs to budget for

Visa application fees, medicals, certificates and the levy add up across a family. They're manageable and predictable, just plan for them from the beginning.

4

Get advice for anything unusual

A complex history, a past visa refusal or a health condition are all navigable, but they're exactly when a licensed immigration adviser earns their keep. We'll point you to one.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Do I need a job offer before I can get a visa?—

For the main work and residence routes, yes, a job offer from an accredited employer is usually the starting point. That's why we focus on securing the right role first: once the offer is in place, the visa pathway becomes clear and the rest follows. It's far less a queue than three pieces moving together.

Can my profession get me residence?+

Can my partner work and my children go to school?+

How long does a visa take?+

Do I need an immigration adviser?+

— HELPFUL ALONGSIDE THIS STEP

Read a little deeper

[Previous](#)[Driving & licences](#)[All chapters](#)[Next](#)[Bringing pets & belongings](#)

Moving with *pets*

There's one member of the family who isn't mentioned in the employment contract. The dog. Or the cat. And for a great many families, leaving them behind simply isn't an option.

NEW ZEALAND

Moving to New Zealand · **Chapter 10 of 15** All 15 chapters →

PAGE AT A GLANCE



Kettle on. A longer read – about 13 min

1. [Start planning early](#)
2. [The two countries' rules](#)
3. [Will they quarantine?](#)
4. [They needn't travel with you](#)
5. [Finding a pet-friendly home](#)
6. [What it costs](#)
7. [The flight itself](#)
8. [Older pets & restrictions](#)
9. [The first few weeks](#)
10. [Useful contacts](#)
11. [Common questions](#)

THE SHORT VERSION

Absolutely possible. Not remotely last-minute.

Moving pets to New Zealand works from many countries, and thousands of families do it every year. But it requires considerably more planning than booking an extra seat on the flight.

New Zealand operates strict biosecurity requirements designed to protect their unique environments and animal health. That means your pet's move needs to be planned alongside your own – not a few weeks before departure.

For most owners, a pet isn't cargo to be transported after the move. They're part of who's moving.

SECTION 01 · TIMING

Start planning early

This is the single most important thing on the page. The process your pet follows depends on the country you are moving *from*, not simply the fact that you're heading to New Zealand.

Requirements can include microchipping, vaccinations, rabies testing, parasite treatments, veterinary examinations, official documentation, import permits and quarantine. And the **order** matters: where a test or treatment has to happen within a specified window, getting the sequence wrong can delay the whole move.

When to start

As soon as New Zealand becomes a serious possibility – not when the removal boxes are packed. You don't need a signed contract to start researching your pet's requirements, and starting early is the cheapest thing you can do.

SECTION 02 • THE RULES

What New Zealand requires

New Zealand sets requirements according to the animal-health and biosecurity risk of your country of export, so two families moving the same breed from different countries can face genuinely different processes.

New Zealand

Strict, and set by MPI

As with Australia, what your dog or cat needs depends partly on where they're travelling from. The process can involve:

An import permit

Microchip identification

Vaccinations and testing

Parasite treatments

Veterinary examinations and official certification

Some pets are also required to enter an approved quarantine facility after arrival. The regulator is the **Ministry for Primary Industries**, and its requirements differ by country of export, so start from its own step-by-step guidance rather than a general checklist: [mpi.govt.nz – bringing cats and dogs to NZ](https://www.mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz/bringing-cats-and-dogs-to-nz) (<https://www.mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz/bringing-cats-and-dogs-to-nz>).

Check the source

Regulations change. A checklist somebody used a few years ago – or even relatively recently – should never replace current government guidance. Check the source, not the forum post.

SECTION 03 • QUARANTINE

Will my pet have to quarantine?

Possibly. It depends on the destination, the animal and the country of origin — New Zealand categorises countries by animal-health and biosecurity risk, and that determines the process.

If quarantine is required, **availability becomes part of your relocation timeline**. Facilities book up, and that's one of the clearest reasons pet travel shouldn't be left until the end of the process.

Three dates, not one

Your employment start date, your family's flights and your pet's travel date may not be the same. Plan them as three linked decisions rather than assuming everyone arrives together.

SECTION 04 • SEQUENCING

Your pet doesn't necessarily have to travel with you

This can feel strange at first, particularly if your pet has always been part of family life. But it is often the most practical option.

A clinician might travel first, begin work, move out of temporary accommodation and secure a pet-friendly long-term rental before their partner, children and pets follow. Other families move together and arrange for the pet to arrive separately.

There isn't one correct way. Think about what makes the transition easiest for both your family and your animal — and remember that arriving into a settled home is a much gentler landing for a dog than arriving into a serviced apartment and a house-hunt.

SECTION 05 • SOMEWHERE TO LIVE

Finding a pet-friendly rental

Getting your pet into the country is only half the problem. You also need somewhere to live that will have them.

Check the rules around pets before assuming a property is suitable — and pay particular attention to temporary accommodation. A serviced apartment or short-term let that works perfectly for a family may not accept a dog or cat. If your pet is arriving after you, use that window to find suitable long-term accommodation.

Then think beyond whether the landlord permits pets:

Is there enough space?

Is there a secure garden, if you have a dog?

Are there good places nearby for walking?

How long will your pet be alone while you're working?

The right home for your family needs to work for them too.

SECTION 06 • COST

How much does it cost?

Pet relocation can be expensive. The total depends on where you're travelling from, your destination, the size and type of animal, veterinary requirements, transport arrangements and whether quarantine is required.

Potential expenses include veterinary appointments, vaccinations, blood tests, official certification, permits, airline transport, travel crates, pet relocation companies and quarantine. For a large dog or multiple animals, the total can become a significant part of the family's relocation budget.

Get quotes early

It is far easier to plan for this six months out than to discover it once you've committed most of your savings to flights, accommodation and setting up the new home. Our [relocation cost guide](#) shows where this sits against everything else you'll be paying for.

SECTION 07 • THE JOURNEY

What is the flight actually like for them?

Understandably one of the biggest worries for owners — and international pet travel is very different from taking an animal on a short domestic journey.

The journey

Ask for it stage by stage

Depending on the route and airline arrangements, your pet may travel in a specially designed crate in an appropriate part of the aircraft rather than alongside you in the cabin. There may also be stopovers or transfers.

A reputable pet transport specialist or airline should be able to explain the journey clearly, including where your animal will be during each stage. If your pet is elderly or has a medical condition, discuss the proposed route with your vet well in advance.

Medication & sedation

Not your decision to make alone

If you're worried about how your pet will cope, speak to your vet *and* the company responsible for transporting them.

Sedation can create additional risks during air travel and may not be permitted or recommended in some circumstances. The right approach depends on the individual animal and the requirements of the carrier — so ask both, and follow the advice.

Should you use a pet relocation company?

You don't have to manage all of this alone. Specialists can coordinate veterinary timelines, documentation, travel crates, flights and quarantine arrangements — at a cost. Some families value having someone run a complicated process while they're simultaneously dealing with visas, registration, jobs, schools and their own move; others prefer to manage it themselves. If you do use one, establish exactly what the quote includes and what you'll still need to arrange separately.

SECTION 08 • CHECK BEFORE YOU SPEND

Older pets, restricted breeds & other animals

Three situations where the answer needs checking before you spend any money on the process.

Older pets

A different conversation

Moving a healthy three-year-old dog and moving a fourteen-year-old dog are very different decisions. For an older animal, the length of the journey, underlying conditions and ability to cope with transport all need careful thought.

That doesn't automatically mean an older pet can't relocate. It means the decision belongs with your vet, rather than resting on whether the paperwork permits it.

Breeds & species

Some animals can't come

New Zealand restricts the importation of certain dog breeds or types, and there can be restrictions affecting hybrid animals. If there's any possibility your dog falls within a restricted category, check the official rules first — don't rely on appearance, breeder descriptions or informal advice.

For pets other than dogs and cats — birds, rabbits, reptiles — don't assume the dog-and-cat process applies. Check whether your animal can legally be imported before making any plans. For some species and countries of origin, it may not be possible at all.

SECTION 09 • SETTLING IN

The first few weeks after arrival

The journey is only one part of your pet's transition. Everything familiar has changed — their home has gone, the smells are different, the routine has changed, and the family is stressed and surrounded by boxes.

Establish a predictable routine as quickly as you can. Find a local vet, update identification details where required, and learn the local rules for registration, microchipping and dog control.

Then do the enjoyable part. Find the walks. Find the parks. Find the beach.

For a lot of families, exploring the new neighbourhood with the dog is the first thing that makes the place feel like home.

SECTION 10 • THE PACKAGE

Could your employer help?

Pet relocation isn't normally a standard employment benefit – but that isn't quite the end of the question.

If your employer is providing a general relocation allowance rather than paying only specified expenses, you may have some flexibility over how that money is used.

Never assume pet transport is covered. Ask what the relocation contribution can and cannot be used for before making any bookings.

Our [offer guide](#) covers how to raise this well – and relocation support is often more negotiable than the salary itself.

USEFUL CONTACTS

Specialists & quarantine facilities

You don't have to organise an international pet move alone. Specialist relocation companies can coordinate veterinary requirements, documentation, flights, travel crates and quarantine arrangements. For candidates relocating from the UK, established providers include:

PetAir UK

A vet-led international pet relocation company providing services to Australia and New Zealand.

Airpets International

Heathrow-based international pet transport specialist with veterinary and animal-handling facilities.

PBS Pet Travel

UK pet relocation company arranging international transport for dogs, cats and other animals.

Quarantine in New Zealand

MPI-approved private facilities

New Zealand uses MPI-approved private quarantine facilities. Current facilities include:

Pethaven Quarantine Services – Auckland

Qualified Pet Services — Auckland

Canterbury Quarantine Services — Christchurch

Requirements for importing animals depend on the country your pet is travelling from, and they change without notice — always check the current [Ministry for Primary Industries guidance](https://www.mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz/bringing-cats-and-dogs-to-nz) (<https://www.mpi.govt.nz/bring-send-to-nz/pets-travelling-to-nz/bringing-cats-and-dogs-to-nz>) before making arrangements. **Ethicare does not receive commission from any of the providers listed here.** We'd recommend obtaining several quotes and confirming current government requirements directly before you book anything.

Sophie's insight

I should declare an interest: we are all completely soft about animals here, and there are two dogs in the Ethicare office on any given day. So when someone tells me they won't move without their dog, I don't treat that as a complication to be worked around — it's just one of the things that has to work. What I'd say honestly is that this is the part of a relocation people leave latest and regret most, because the timings are fixed by regulation and no amount of goodwill speeds them up. Raise it with us in the first conversation, not the last. It's far easier to build the whole move around your pet's timeline than to discover six weeks before departure that the sequence doesn't work.

Sophie Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

— COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions we're asked about moving with pets

How far in advance should I start?—

As soon as the move becomes a serious possibility. Several of the veterinary steps have to happen in a particular order and within specified windows, and quarantine facilities have finite availability — so the timeline is set by regulation rather than by how organised you are. Starting early costs nothing and prevents the most common delays.

Will my dog definitely have to go into quarantine?+

Can my pet travel on the same flight as me?+

Should my pet be sedated for the journey?+

My dog is a restricted breed — is that the end of it?+

What about a rabbit, bird or reptile?+

Will an employer pay for pet relocation?+

EXPLORE FURTHER

Read a little deeper

[Previous](#)[Your move, step by step](#)[All chapters](#)[Next](#)[Before you leave home](#)

Before you leave home

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 11 of 15

A simple list to work through in the weeks before you fly. Tick each item off as you go.

Documents

Passport and valid NZ work or resident visa (printed copy too)
Your job offer and employment contract
Qualifications and professional certificates
References and employment history
Digital and printed copies of everything important

Money & admin

Apply online for a NZ bank account before you travel
Bring proof of ID and address to verify the account in person
Have your documents ready to apply for an IRD number on arrival
Arrange international money transfer for your initial funds

Travel & the move

Confirm your airline baggage allowance and pre-purchase extra if needed
Book temporary accommodation for your first weeks
Get quotes from removal companies if shipping belongings
Pack essentials, documents and valuables in your carry-on

Your first month

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 12 of 15

Four weeks, in the order that actually works. Some of these tasks depend on each other, and doing them out of sequence is what costs people time.



Kettle on. A longer read — about 7 min

Four things unlock everything else

They have to happen roughly in this order, because each one is asked for by the next. Get the chain right and the first fortnight is easy. Get it wrong and you'll spend a month being told to come back with something you don't have yet.

1 · A New Zealand address

Everything else is asked in relation to it. A short-term rental, serviced apartment or a friend's spare room all count — you don't need the permanent one yet.

2 · A bank account

Open it before you fly if you can; most banks let you start the process from overseas and finish it in branch with your passport and address.

3 · An IRD number

Apply in your first few days. It needs the address and the bank account, and your employer needs it before your first pay run.

4 · A phone number

Asked for by almost every form, appointment and rental application you'll make. A prepay SIM at the airport is enough to start.

The one that costs real money

Your employer will ask you to complete an **IR330 tax code declaration** before your first pay run. If you have no IRD number yet, you're taxed at the no-notification rate — considerably higher than your real rate — until you produce one. It's refunded eventually, but "eventually" can mean the end of the tax year. Open the bank account before you fly, apply for the IRD number in your first few days, and this never becomes a problem.

Four weeks, roughly

Adjust for who's arriving with you – the list changes quite a lot if there are children in it.

Week one · Land and anchor

Sleep, a SIM card, the bank account finished in branch, the IRD application in. Walk your temporary neighbourhood. Register the household with a GP near where you'll actually live. Feels: disorienting, and faster than you expected.

Week two · Wheels and paperwork

Start the licence conversion, rent or buy a car, get an a local public transport card. First shifts and orientation. If children are with you, contact schools and check the zone for any address before you sign. Feels: busy, productive, tiring.

Week three · Viewings and the dip

Serious house-hunting, references ready, applications in the same day. Somewhere in here the adrenaline runs out. Feels: harder than week one, and completely normal.

Week four · Settle and join

Lease signed, utilities and broadband connected, KiwiSaver decided. Join one thing that isn't work. Feels: like the beginning of an ordinary life rather than a very long trip.

Around week three, most people crash a bit

The first fortnight runs on adrenaline and admin. There's a list, the list gets shorter, and every day contains something new. Then the list runs out, the novelty thins, and you're left in a house you didn't choose carefully, in a city where you know six people, doing a job in a system that does things slightly differently from the one you spent your career learning.

It usually lands somewhere between day fifteen and day twenty-five. It's extremely common, it says nothing whatsoever about whether you made the right decision, and it passes.

What helps is knowing it's coming. What helps more is having something in the calendar for that week that isn't admin.

Six things that won't be done in a month

A month is enough to be functional. It isn't enough to be settled, and expecting otherwise is the commonest way people make the first year harder than it needs to be.

Feeling at home in the department

Three to six months before the systems, the shorthand and the referral pathways stop taking conscious effort.

A settled circle of friends

Six to twelve months, and it depends almost entirely on what you joined in month one.

Knowing the city

A year, and a few wrong turns. You'll pick the right beach for the conditions eventually.

The right house

Most people move once. Renting first and choosing properly second is the sensible plan, not a failure.

Residency, if that's the plan

Measured in years rather than months, and worth starting the paperwork trail early.

Not converting every price

Six months or so before you stop doing mental exchange-rate arithmetic in the supermarket.

“Do one non-essential thing in your first week. A walk up a volcano, a swim, a ferry to nowhere in particular. It will feel indulgent when you have a hundred jobs on a list — that is exactly why it works. The admin will still be there on Monday, and you will have one memory of the place that is not a queue or a form. Start collecting those early.”

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING

Each of these has a chapter of its own when you need the detail: **Money, tax & banking** for your IRD number, first payslip and KiwiSaver; **Driving & licences** for converting your licence and buying a car; and **Schools & education** for zoning and enrolment.

The shape of the first year

The week-three dip is the first bend in a longer curve. Most people describe the same four phases on roughly the same timetable, and knowing the shape in advance takes most of the alarm out of the middle of it.

First weeks

The honeymoon

Everything is new — the scenery, the accents, the supermarket — and the adrenaline of setting up a life carries most of it. It does not stay this heightened, and that is not a loss.

First months

The dip

Once the novelty thins, the distance from home, the small frustrations and the effort of starting over tend to arrive together. It is the part nobody warns people about, it is well documented, and it says nothing about whether the decision was right. Naming it takes away most of its power.

Around six months

Finding your feet

Routines form: a GP, a favourite beach, people you would call on a bad day. Work stops taking conscious effort, the children have friends, and the place stops feeling like somewhere you are visiting.

The first year

Home

You stop converting prices, you know the back roads, and you are the one giving the next arrival directions. It rarely happens in a moment. Somewhere in the first year, it has happened.

Looking after yourself through it

Admin and friendships are only part of it. Four things people who have been through the dip tend to say they wish they had known earlier.

Homesickness is normal, not failure

Missing home does not mean the decision was wrong; it means you valued what you left. It softens as the new life fills in around it, and saying it out loud shortens the process.

Stay connected, and be here

Regular calls home help. Living entirely online keeps one foot in the old life. Plan the trips back, then let yourself be fully here in between.

Judge it at a year, not at month three

The first year has seasons, literally and emotionally. A “was this a mistake?” decision taken in the dip is taken on the worst evidence you will ever have. Most people who waited are glad they did.

Ask for help early

A GP, a community group, a colleague, or us. Reaching out early is what the people who settled did, not a sign of struggling.

The people side has a chapter of its own, [finding your community](#), and if a partner or children are moving with you, so does [moving with your family](#). What we do in those months is set out once, on [the About page](#).

The relocation checklist

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 13 of 15

Everything in the guide, as a list you can tick off. It saves as you go, so you can close this and come back to it in a fortnight.

Six stages, from three months before you leave to three months after you land. Nothing here is urgent on its own — the point is that none of it arrives as a surprise. Not every line applies to every household; skip what doesn't.

0 of 0 done

Saved in this browser only — it doesn't leave your device and we can't see it. Use the same browser and it will be here when you come back.

“A list this long looks like a mountain when you are standing at the bottom of it. It is not. It is roughly forty small errands spread over six months, and most of them take under an hour. Do the ones with a lead time first — pets, schools, the bank account — and let the rest arrive in their own order. Nobody has ever done all of this perfectly, and everybody has still arrived.”

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING

A DIFFERENT QUESTION

This checklist answers *when*. There's another for *what applies to me*.

The list above is the timeline — around forty errands in the order they need doing. If you'd rather start from who's moving, our moving checklist builds itself around your household: partner work rights, school-age children, under-fives, a pet, or moving out ahead of the family.

Build my moving checklist →

Finding your people

A new job is only half of a move. The other half is belonging: faith, culture, friendship and a taste of home.

Moving to New Zealand · Chapter 14 of 15 All 15 chapters →

PAGE AT A GLANCE



Kettle on. A longer read — about 12 min

1. [Faith & worship](#)
2. [Cultural communities](#)
3. [An inclusive welcome](#)
4. [Manaakitanga](#)
5. [A taste of home](#)
6. [Finding your community](#)
7. [Useful links](#)

WHY THIS MATTERS

Belonging is what makes a move last

The clinicians who settle for good aren't the ones with the biggest salary. They're the ones who found their people — a place to worship, a familiar festival, a friend who cooks the food of home.

A family festival at Victoria Park, Palmerston North. Small towns run more of these than cities do, and they are usually where newcomers meet people first.

New Zealand is a multicultural country. Its cities and towns are home to long-established Māori and Pacific communities alongside large Asian, Middle Eastern, African and European populations, and the healthcare workforce itself is wonderfully international. Whatever your faith, culture or background, the odds are good that a community already exists, ready to welcome you.

If there's one promise in this guide, it's this: **you will not have to leave who you are behind to move here.** Belonging takes a little time and a little effort, but the ingredients are all here, waiting.

FAITH & PLACES OF WORSHIP

A place to worship, whatever your faith

Freedom of religion is protected in law, and there are active communities across all the major faiths. In the cities especially, you'll find established congregations, and many smaller towns have more than newcomers expect.

Christian

Churches of every tradition

From Anglican, Catholic and Presbyterian to Pentecostal and a wide range of ethnic-specific congregations, Christian communities are found in every city and most towns: many with services in languages other than English.

Muslim

Mosques & Islamic centres

Established Muslim communities in the main centres run mosques, Islamic centres and schools, with halal food increasingly easy to find. Smaller cities have growing congregations and prayer spaces too.

Hindu

Temples & cultural life

A large and active Hindu community supports temples and cultural associations, with major festivals such as Diwali celebrated publicly in the cities, often as city-wide events.

Sikh

Gurdwaras & community

A growing Sikh population maintains gurdwaras in the main centres, offering worship, langar and a strong sense of community for new arrivals.

Buddhist

Temples & meditation

Buddhist temples and meditation centres reflect New Zealand's diverse Asian communities, welcoming both heritage practitioners and newcomers to the practice.

Jewish & others

Smaller, settled communities

Long-established Jewish congregations and a range of other faith communities are present, particularly in the larger cities. If your faith is part of your life, it can stay that way here.

A practical tip

Faith communities are often the fastest route to friendship and practical help when you arrive: many run welcome groups, share local knowledge and lend a hand with the early settling-in. It's worth reaching out before you even land.

CULTURAL & DIASPORA COMMUNITIES

Chances are, your community is already here

Healthcare professionals come to New Zealand from all over the world, and where people settle, communities form. You'll find cultural associations, social groups and informal networks that make the distance from home feel a great deal smaller.

Rezon and his wife celebrating Onam with colleagues in Palmerston North: the sadya served on banana leaves, and the family dressed for the day.

Rezon, Neethu and Anu's first year in Palmerston North →

Established diaspora networks

Large and active communities from the UK and Ireland, India, the Philippines, South Africa, China and across the Pacific mean cultural associations, social events and familiar faces are rarely far away.

Professional peer groups

Because so many clinicians have made this exact move, you'll find others in your profession who share your background: people who understand both the work and the journey, and are generous with advice.

Cultural festivals & events

Diwali, Eid, Lunar New Year, Pasifika and many more are celebrated openly and often city-wide: public, joyful occasions that make it easy to stay connected to your heritage and share it with new friends.

Community language & schooling

Many communities run weekend language and culture classes so children stay connected to their heritage language and traditions while they grow up as young New Zealanders.

Social media & local groups

Active online groups for almost every nationality and city are where newcomers ask questions, find housing, swap recommendations and arrange the first real-life catch-ups.

Sport & shared interests

Cricket, football, rugby, cultural dance, choirs and hobby clubs are some of the easiest, most natural ways to meet people who share both your interests and, often, your background.

“I was surprised by how strong the Keralan community is in Manawatū. There are lots of families here and people were incredibly welcoming when we arrived. Having people around who understand where you’ve come from, while you’re also building a new life in New Zealand, really helped us settle.”

A clinician’s family on settling in Manawatū

AN INCLUSIVE WELCOME

A country that welcomes you as you are

New Zealand has a strong, settled culture of inclusion, backed by law. People are protected from discrimination on the grounds of race, religion, gender, sexual orientation and more, and, just as importantly, acceptance is woven into everyday life.

LGBTQ+ communities

New Zealand is widely regarded as one of the most welcoming places in the world for LGBTQ+ people, with legal equality, visible communities and Pride events in the main centres.

Equality at work

Workplaces, including across the health system, take inclusion and anti-discrimination seriously. You should expect to be treated with respect and fairness as a matter of course.

Families of every shape

Single parents, blended families, same-sex parents and multi-generational households are all an ordinary, accepted part of New Zealand life.

TE AO MĀORI

Manaakitanga, the welcome at the heart of it

One of the first Māori words you’ll come across is manaakitanga: caring for others, hospitality and generosity towards newcomers. It isn’t a slogan – it’s something most newcomers notice early.

As a newcomer you’ll be welcomed into a country shaped by **Te Tiriti o Waitangi** and the relationship between Māori and the Crown. Understanding a little of this, the role of te reo Māori, the customs of a *pōwhiri* (welcome) or a *karakia* (blessing) you may encounter at work is part of settling in respectfully and well. It’s also one of the quiet privileges of making your life here.

You don't need to know everything on arrival. **A willingness to learn and to show respect goes a long way**, and our **About New Zealand guide** covers the history, Te Tiriti and te reo in more depth.

A TASTE OF HOME

The small comforts that matter most

It's the little things that catch people out: the spice you can't find, the snack from childhood. New Zealand's diversity means most are closer than you'd think.

Food & groceries

International supermarkets and specialist grocers in the cities stock ingredients from across Asia, the Middle East, Africa and Europe. Halal, kosher and a huge range of cultural foods are increasingly available, and online ordering fills most gaps.

Restaurants & community kitchens

From regional Indian and Filipino to Middle Eastern, Korean and beyond, you'll find restaurants and takeaways serving the real thing, and community events where home cooking is shared generously.

Festivals & traditions

The celebrations you grew up with are very likely marked here too, often publicly. Keeping your own traditions alive, and being invited into others', is part of what makes life here rich.

International & Asian supermarkets

Big world-food ranges and dedicated Asian grocers.

Tai Ping Asian Supermarket (<https://www.taiping.co.nz>)

The Asian Grocer (online) (<https://www.asiangrocer.co.nz>)

New World, world-food aisles (<https://www.newworld.co.nz>)

UK & British specialists

British groceries, sweets, biscuits & tea.

UK Foods NZ (<https://ukfoods.co.nz>)

A Little Bit of Britain (<https://www.alittlebitofbritain.co.nz>)

British Food Imports (<https://britishfoodimports.co.nz>)

South African specialists

Biltong, boerewors, braai & pantry staples.

Something From Home (<https://www.somethingfromhome.co.nz>)

The South African Shop (<https://sashopnz.co.nz>)

Biltong & Wors Shop (<https://worsshop.co.nz>)

The big supermarkets — New World, PAK'nSAVE and Woolworths. All carry growing international aisles, and most cities have large Asian grocers such as Lim Chhour and Da Hua alongside Indian, Korean, Middle Eastern and Pacific specialists. Links open external sites we don't control, and range and availability vary by region.

Halal

Halal food is widely available, especially in the main centres. Many mainstream supermarkets and butchers stock halal-certified meat (FIANZ is the country's main halal certifier), and cities have dedicated halal butchers, grocers and restaurants. In smaller towns the choice narrows, but it's rarely far away.

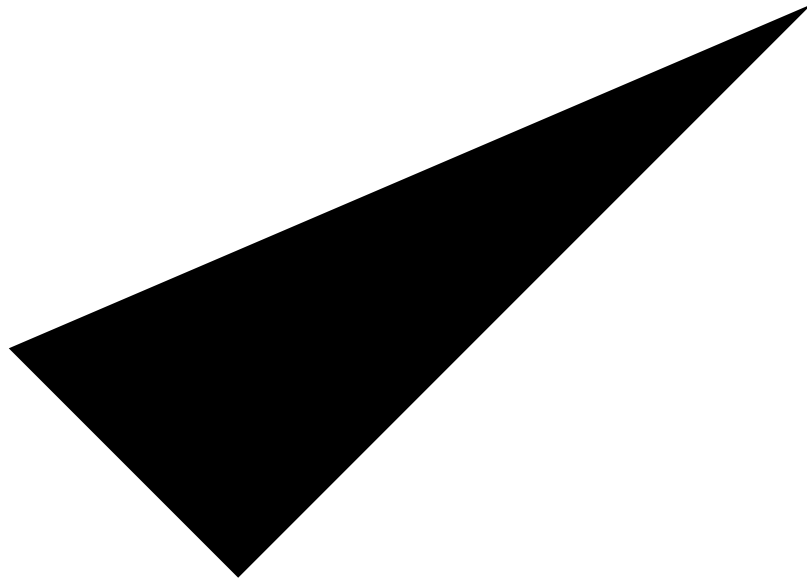
Kosher

Kosher options are more limited but present — Auckland has the widest range, including a kosher store and deli, and Wellington has some too. Elsewhere it's mostly online or through the local Jewish community. The [New Zealand Jewish Council](#) and local congregations are the best people to point you to current suppliers.

PRACTICAL FIRST STEPS

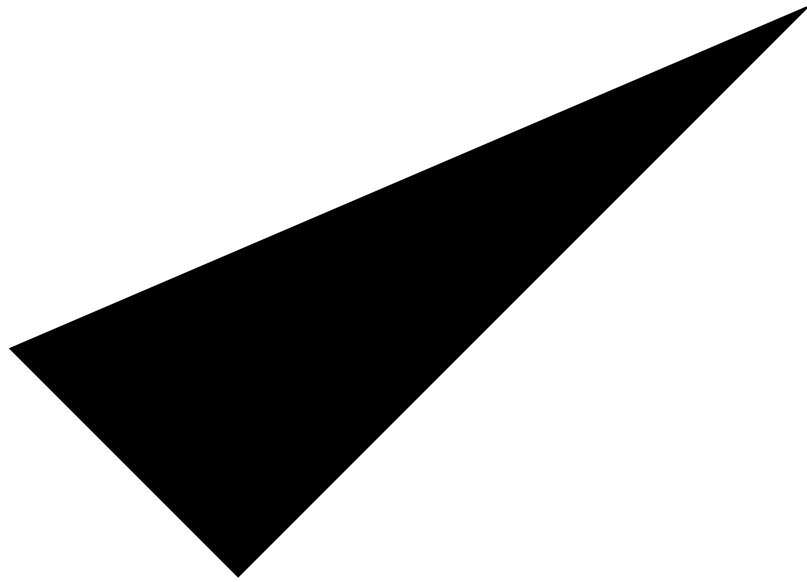
How to find your people, quickly

Community rarely just appears, but a little intention in your first weeks makes all the difference. These are the things we suggest to every clinician we place, and they work.



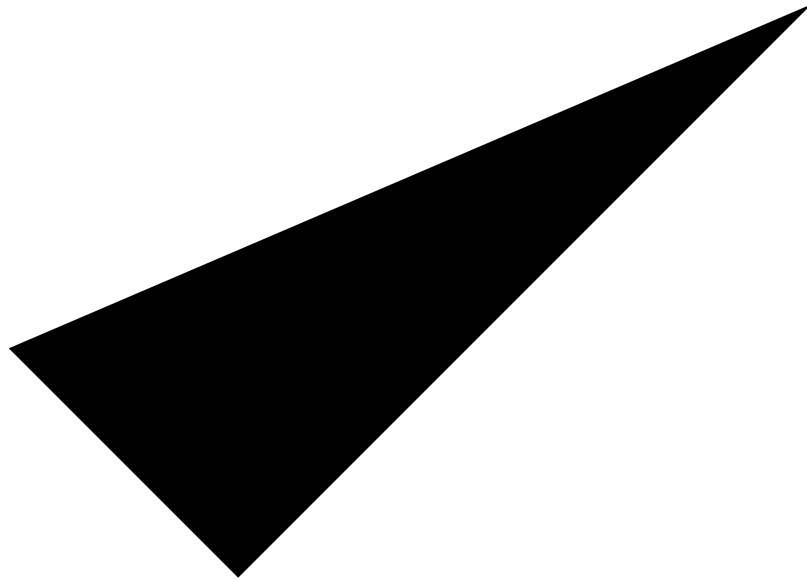
Connect before you arrive

Search online for groups linked to your nationality, faith or city. Introducing yourself early means a friendly contact or two before you even land.



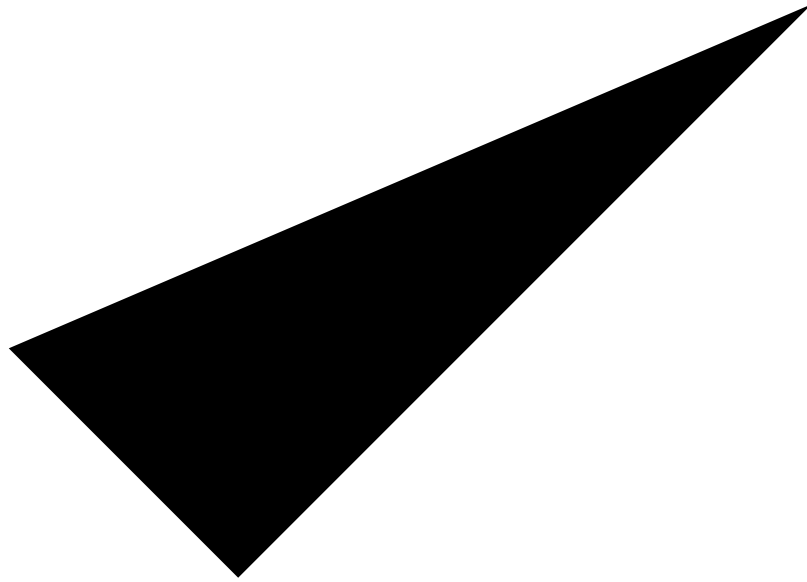
Say yes early and often

The first invitations, a coffee, a barbecue, a community event, are how roots begin. Accepting them, even when you're tired, pays off quickly.



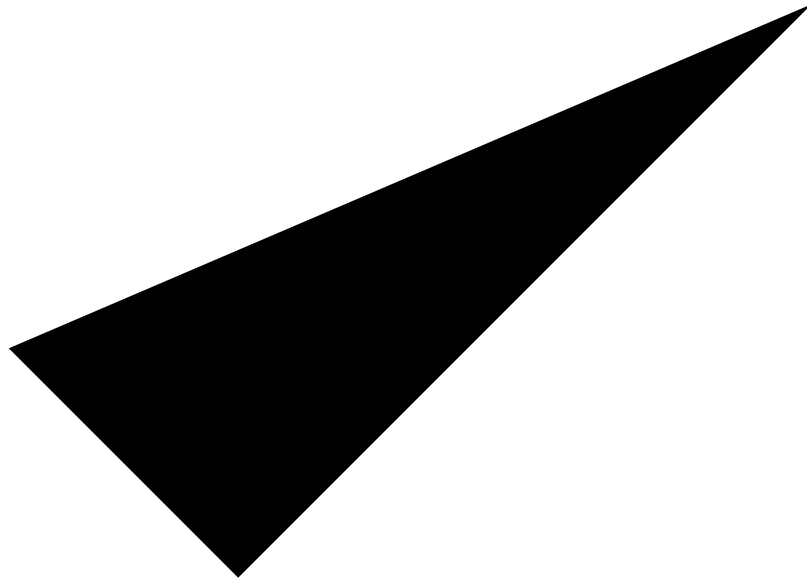
Use your workplace

Colleagues are often your first community, and many have made the same move. Ask them where to worship, shop and gather, they'll know.



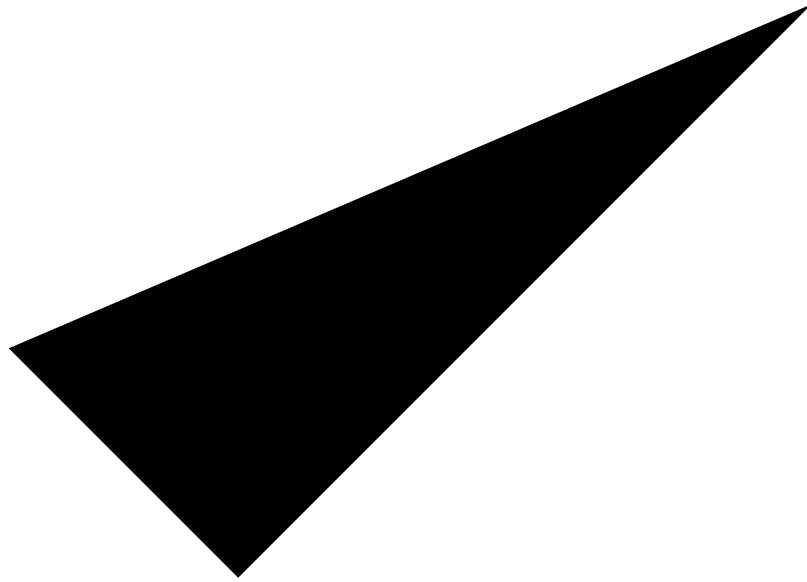
Join one regular thing

A weekly class, sports team, choir or place of worship gives your week an anchor and the same faces each time, which is how acquaintances become friends.



Bring your culture with you

Cook for new neighbours, share your festivals, contribute what's yours. Belonging flows both ways, and people love being welcomed into something new.



Ask us

We know the communities in the regions we place people, and we're always happy to point you towards the right groups, places and people for your family.

— WHERE TO START

Useful links, faith bodies & community

The national organisations for the major faiths, each with regional centres in the main cities, plus a couple of practical ways to find local groups wherever you settle.

Christian churches

National churches with parishes nationwide.

Catholic Church in New Zealand (https://www.catholic.org.nz)

Anglican Church in Aotearoa, NZ & Polynesia (https://www.anglican.org.nz)

Presbyterian Church of Aotearoa NZ (https://www.presbyterian.org.nz)

Finding people locally

Local groups, societies and a friendly introduction.

Citizens Advice Bureau directory (https://www.cab.org.nz)

Ask Ethicare for an introduction ↗

Sikh, Buddhist and many other faith communities also have well-established gurdwaras, temples and centres across the main cities, as do a great many cultural and national societies. If you can't find yours, tell us where you're moving and what matters to you, and we'll point you to the nearest community. For newcomer networks and a region-by-region list of local groups, see [Useful contacts](#). Links open on external sites we don't control.

Other major faiths

National peak bodies, with centres in each main city.

Federation of Islamic Associations of NZ (https://fianz.com)

Hindu Council of New Zealand (https://hcnz.org)

New Zealand Jewish Council (https://nzjc.org.nz)

Sophie's insight

People worry, quietly, about whether they'll fit in, whether they'll find somewhere to pray, food that tastes like home, friends who understand them. I understand that worry completely. What I've seen is how much is already here, and how warmly people are received once they reach out. The clinicians who thrive are the ones who let New Zealand welcome them and who keep hold of their own culture at the same time. You don't have to choose. Helping a family find their community, the temple, the grocer, the weekend cricket, is some of the most rewarding work we do.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions people ask us about belonging

Will I be able to practise my religion freely?+

Is there a community of people from my country?+

How welcoming is New Zealand to LGBTQ+ people?+

Can I find the food and ingredients I'm used to?+

What if I'm moving somewhere smaller and quieter?+

KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

PreviousThe relocation checklistAll chaptersNextKey numbers to know

Useful contacts, websites & community

The official links you'll actually need, and the people we trust to help you settle.

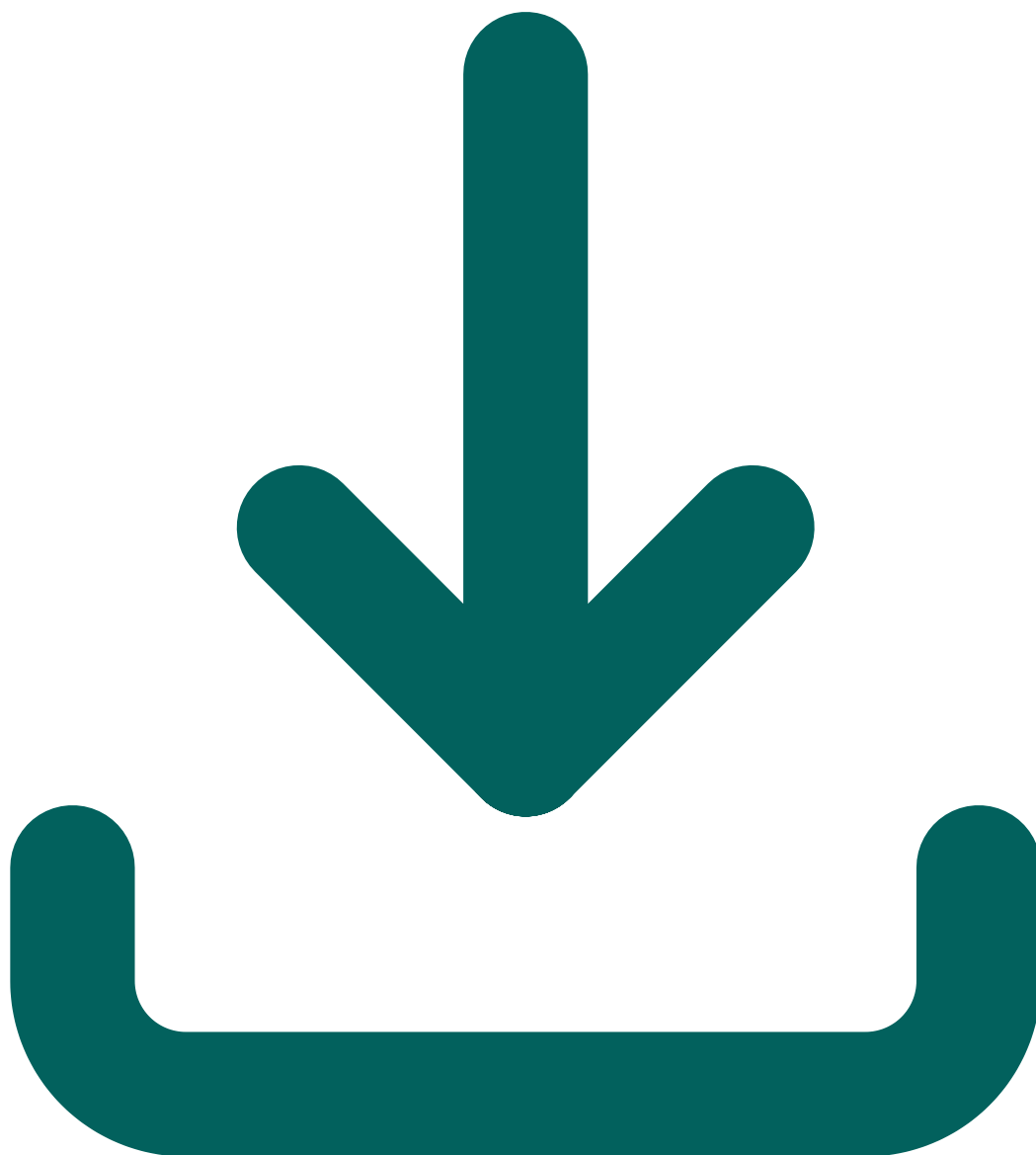
Kettle on. A longer read — about 5 min

Moving to New Zealand · **Chapter 15 of 15** All 15 chapters →

FREE DOWNLOADABLE GUIDES

Practical guides you can keep

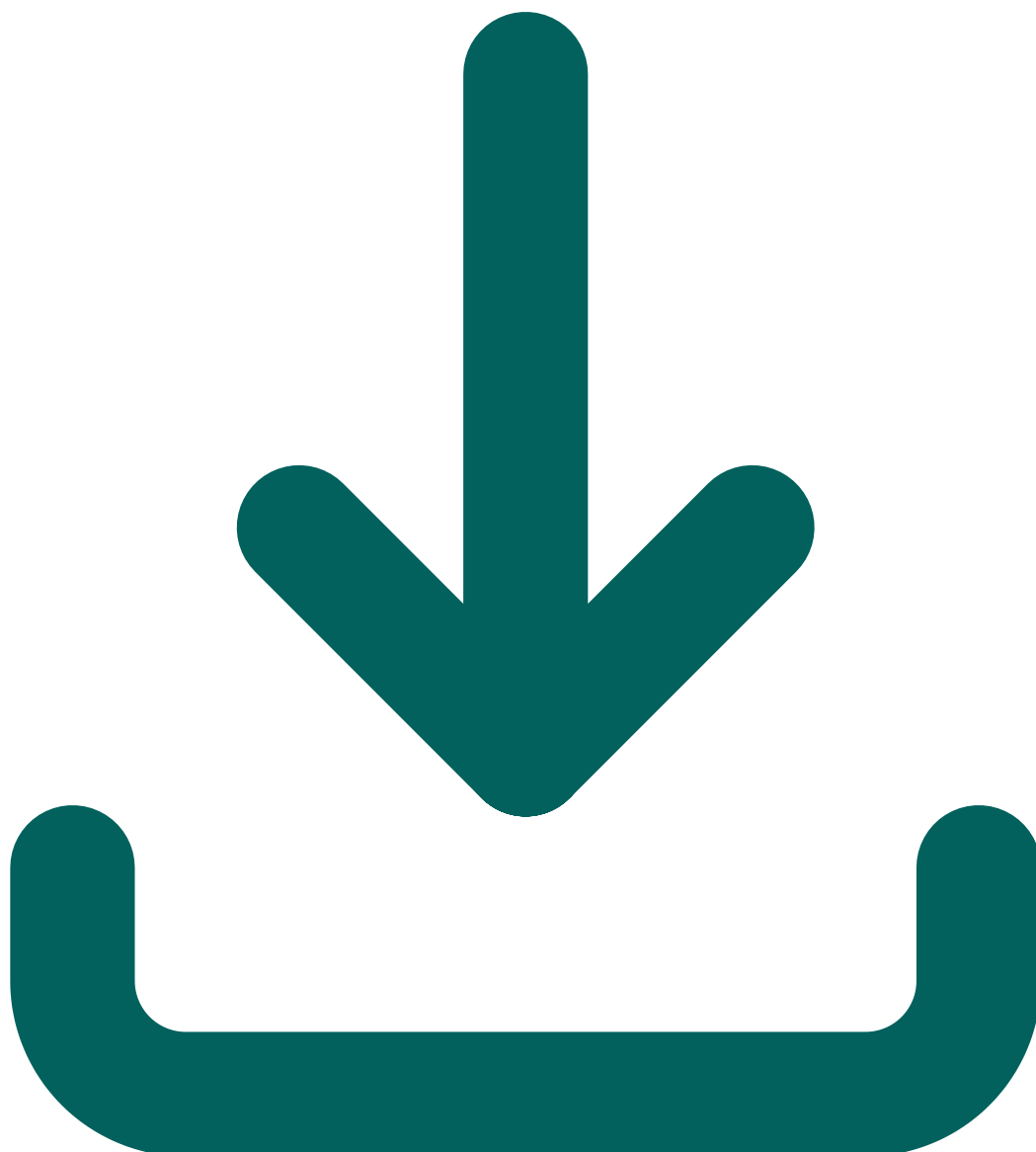
No-nonsense, honest guides to download and read at your own pace, written from years of helping healthcare professionals make this move.



Interview Preparation Guide

How to prepare for New Zealand healthcare interviews: STAR answers, common questions and calm, practical advice.

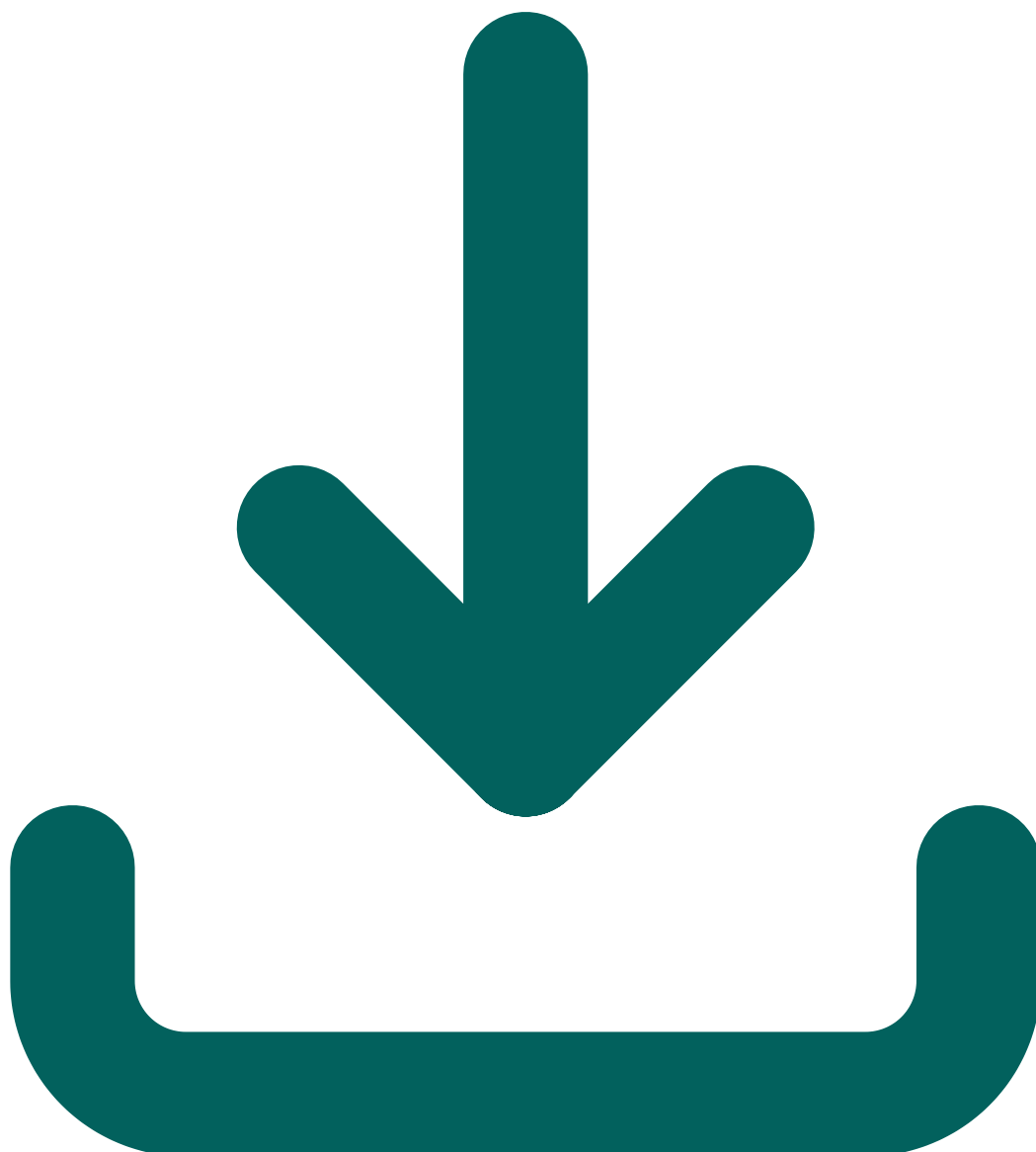
[Download PDF ↓](#)



Build your CV

Presenting your experience clearly for New Zealand employers: structure, what to include and what to leave out. Guided, on your device, and it gives you a file to send.

[Open the CV builder →](#)



Moving to New Zealand

Our national guide, printed as a book: registration, visas, shipping, housing, schools and those first few weeks.

[Request a copy →](#)

— OFFICIAL LINKS & EVERYDAY CONTACTS

The official websites, in one place

A handful of trustworthy, official sources for the practical questions: healthcare, schools, visas, tax and the cost of everyday life. More specific links live within the relevant profession guides.

Living in New Zealand

Visas, wages and the bigger picture

Immigration New Zealand

(<https://www.immigration.govt.nz>)

Stats NZ · wages & cost of living

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz>)

Sorted · money & budgeting

(<https://sorted.org.nz>)

Settling in

The practical everyday

Inland Revenue (IRD)

(<https://www.ird.govt.nz>)

Tenancy Services · renting

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz>)

Waka Kotahi · driver licences

(<https://www.nzta.govt.nz/driver-licences/>)

For your family

Healthcare, schools and support

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora

(<https://www.tewhatauora.govt.nz>)

Find a school & check zones

(<https://www.educationcounts.govt.nz/find-school>)

Citizens Advice Bureau

(<https://www.cab.org.nz>)

Official bodies and current rules are always best confirmed at the source: details can change. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not licensed immigration advisers.

FAITH, CULTURE & COMMUNITY

Finding your community

The national bodies for the major faiths, the organisations that help newcomers settle, and a region-by-region starting point for local groups. For the warm, full guide to belonging, see [Religion, community & belonging](#).

Christian churches

National churches, parishes nationwide.

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(<https://www.catholic.org.nz>)

Anglican Church in Aotearoa, NZ & Polynesia

(<https://www.anglican.org.nz>)

Other major faiths

National peak bodies, with centres in each main city.

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(<https://fianz.com>)

Hindu Council of New Zealand

(<https://hcnz.org>)

New Zealand Jewish Council

(<https://nzjc.org.nz>)

Presbyterian Church of Aotearoa NZ

(<https://www.presbyterian.org.nz>)

Newcomer & multicultural support

Settling in and finding people.

Citizens Advice Bureau

(<https://www.cab.org.nz>)

Ministry for

Ethnic

(<https://www.ethniccommunities.govt.nz>)

Communities

Multicultural New Zealand

New Zealand Newcomers Network

Belong Aotearoa

Regional groups, by area

Examples to look up once you know where you're headed, a starting point, not an exhaustive list. Tell us your destination and we'll point you to the right local groups.

Auckland+

Wellington+

Christchurch & Canterbury+

Waikato (Hamilton)+

Manawatū (Palmerston North)+

Bay of Plenty (Tauranga & Rotorua)+

Northland (Whangarei)+

Nelson, Tasman & Marlborough+

Otago (Dunedin)+

Hawke's Bay+

Links open external sites we don't control. The regional groups are examples to help you start; availability changes over time, so if you can't find yours, just ask, we know the communities in the regions where we place people.

YOU WON'T ARRIVE TO STRANGERS

Trusted partners & finding your community

Settling somewhere new is about more than a job. Over the years we have built relationships with people and services we rate – a community, a place of worship, or where to buy the foods that taste like home.

Partner we trust English & exams

Swoosh English

Friendly, focused IELTS and OET preparation for healthcare professionals, so the language test is the least of your worries.

Visit Swoosh English (<https://swooshenglish.com>)

Relocation & shipping

Moving your life over

Trusted relocation and shipping partners who handle the logistics, from container to doorstep, so you can focus on your family.

Ask us for an introduction

Faith & worship

Your place of worship

Churches, mosques, temples and faith communities near where you'll live. See our dedicated guide to faith and religion in New Zealand.

Religion in New Zealand

Your people

National & cultural communities

South African, Filipino, Indian and many other communities are well established here. We're glad to connect you with families who've walked the same path.

Ask us for an introduction

A taste of home

Familiar groceries

From biltong and boerewors to spices and Asian supermarkets, we can point you to where to find the ingredients you'll miss most.

Ask us for an introduction

Online & local

Groups & networks

Facebook groups, parents' networks and profession circles where newcomers ask the small questions and find quick, kind answers.

Ask us for an introduction

These are relationships, not adverts. Tell us where you're moving from and what matters to your family, and we'll point you to the people we trust.

— KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

Previous [Finding your feet & your people](#) [All chapters](#)